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Managing Stress: Black Women in Senior Leadership Positions in Higher Education

By

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CAPSTONE

Submitted in Partial Fulfillment of the Requirements

For the Degree of Doctorate of Education, Ed.D.
Interdisciplinary Leadership – Higher Education Concentration

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by

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ABSTRACT

Northouse (2016) defines leadership as a process in which an individual persuades a group or individuals to achieve a universal objective. When leaders are stressed, it can affect not only their work performance, but also the work performance of the follower. Historically, Black women have been underrepresented in senior leadership positions in higher education, making it critical to study the unique stressors they experience and the strategies they employ to manage them. By developing deeper insight into the experiences of Black women, presidents, institutions, boards, search committees, and search firms can work to remove barriers Black women face in their progression to senior leadership positions (ACE, 2023). Accordingly, this study explored how Black women senior leaders in higher education, specifically at two-year institutions, manage stress.

Using a phenomenological approach, data was collected through semi-structured interviews with Black women serving in senior-level roles across three U.S. regions. Thematic analysis revealed four major themes: (1) the double bind of racism and sexism as a persistent source of stress, (2) the symptoms of stress, including both physical and emotional manifestations, (3) the use of self-care activities such as spirituality, mindfulness, and exercise, and (4) strategic support seeking, particularly through mentorship, professional development, and peer networks.

Findings indicate that while participants encountered systemic barriers and bias in their leadership journeys, they employed intentional coping strategies that sustained their resilience and effectiveness. Mentorship, both formal and informal, emerged as a critical resource, especially when it came from other Black women who could relate to their lived experiences. Institutional professional development opportunities also functioned as affirmations of their

leadership capacity, though such supports were often inconsistent or dependent on individual initiative rather than organizational structures.

The study contributes to the growing body of research on Black women's leadership in higher education by illuminating the intersectional stressors they face, the strategies they employ to navigate them, and the institutional gaps in support. These insights underscore the need for systemic policy and practice changes, including culturally competent mentorship programs, wellness initiatives, and leadership development opportunities, to advance equity and sustain the well-being of Black women leaders.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

I would like to express my deepest gratitude to my committee chair, Dr. Quincy Martin, for your steady guidance, patience, and wisdom throughout this journey. Your support helped me navigate each step of this process with confidence. To Dr. Cooney, thank you for encouraging me at the very beginning when I hesitated to embark on this journey. In moments when imposter syndrome crept in, you reminded me of my worth and pushed me to believe in myself.

I also extend heartfelt thanks to the participants in this study. Your time, insights, and willingness to share your lived experiences were invaluable. Your openness not only enriched this research but also created a powerful narrative that will continue to inspire and guide others.

I am profoundly grateful to my family for their unwavering support. To my husband, Robert, you are my rock, my inspiration, and my greatest encourager. Thank you for stepping in when last-minute deadlines demanded my attention and for reminding me to keep going when I felt like giving up. To my children, I love each of you dearly. You are my reason for persevering. May this serve as a reminder that you can achieve anything you set your mind to.

Finally, I would like to thank God, who is the head of my life. Without Him, none of this would be possible. The many prayers I lifted, often through tears, were answered in ways that gave me strength to persevere, and for that I am forever grateful.

DEDICATION

I lovingly dedicate this work to my mother, Carol Noel Moore. Although you are no longer here to witness this accomplishment, I know that you would be proud of your baby girl and all that I have achieved as a first-generation college student. You always offered encouragement and a listening ear when life became difficult. Thank you for modeling the strength, love, and devotion of a dedicated wife and mother. Your wisdom and guidance continue to carry me, and without them, I could not have endured this journey.

I also dedicate this work to my love, husband, and my best friend, Robert King. Without you by my side, I could not have succeeded in this endeavor. I am forever grateful for your belief in me, your patience, and your unwavering support. Thank you for allowing me to take this step, this is only the beginning, and I know we will accomplish great things together.

Finally, I would like to dedicate this work to my entire family. I love you all deeply, and I am so thankful for your constant encouragement and kind words throughout this process.

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Chapter One

INTRODUCTION

Higher education institutions need diverse and effective leadership to remain successful and productive institutions (Johnson, 2023). By retaining a diverse and effective leadership team, institutions can leverage leaders' identity-related knowledge and experiences to enhance the effectiveness of their core work (Ely & Thomas, 2020). To be effective leaders, educators must first understand what leadership entails. Northouse defines leadership as a process in which an individual persuades a group or individuals to achieve a universal objective (Northouse, 2016). In an environment of complex change, leadership encompasses balance to coordinate actions with values, evaluate options, manage boundaries and relationships, maintain self-awareness, and position professional responsibilities while sustaining a personal life (Hertneky, 2010). Becoming a leader can be difficult and bring on many different feelings including anxiety and stress for both the leader and the follower. Becoming a leader and being a follower can be difficult, requiring both sides to address many different feelings including anxiety and stress.

When leaders are overwhelmed, their stress can affect not only their work performance, but also the work performance of their team. Learning how to manage these issues early is especially important for new leaders who are seeking advancement in their careers to avoid followers' performance issues. Stress costs organizations $200 billion dollars a year through workplace accidents, absenteeism, turnovers, increased health care costs, and a decrease in quantity and quality of production; however, research indicates stress can be reduced by practicing strategies such as mindfulness to promote personal well-being to increase effective leadership (Slaymaker, et al. 2022; Stickle & Scott, 2016). This revelation makes it important to

understand how to manage these issues before they overwhelm the leader, follower, and institution.

Future leaders need to be identified and prepared for the multitude of issues related to managing complex higher education institutions (Teague, 2015). According to Teague (2015), institutions need to begin recruiting leaders with diverse experiences, viewpoints, and backgrounds to encourage differing perspectives that could broaden an institution's world views and foster innovation. Accordingly, it is important to study Black women leaders and the stress they experience in senior leadership positions in higher education. Graham et al. (2022) acknowledged that not enough is known about the specific and distinctive ways in which Black women experience and cope with stress; therefore, the relationship between stress and psychological health is venerable. Isolation, exclusion, and systemic discrimination are some of the psychological stress factors experienced in the workplace by Black women (Slay, 2023). Additionally, cultural taxation, a term coined by Amado Padilla, exposes the increased responsibilities and expectations for Black tenure-track faculty (Slay, 2023). This increased expectation level also contributes to increased psychological stress (Slay, 2023). Since Black women are marginalized in their social statuses of both sex and race, they contend with the challenges of both racism and sexism (Burke et al., 2023). Due to this double minority status, women of color theorists suggest Black women have a higher risk for anxiety disorders (Burke et al., 2023). When faced with multiple challenges, Black women create a persona of the Strong Black Woman (SBW), which portrays an image of being infrangible, capable of enduring hardships unscathed, and with valiant strength (Graham et al., 2023). This internalization of strength can cause unhealthy coping mechanisms such as excessive drinking and binge eating which contributes to cardiovascular disease and obesity amongst Black women (Golden, 2020).

Stress can hinder considerably a leader's ability to adapt and thrive in progressive environments (Slaymaker et al., 2022). Stress occurs when individuals attempt to adjust to an environment comprised of difficult events including pressures from work, marital problems, and financial problems; stress can also develop from pleasant events such as a new job or a promotion (Michailidis & Asimenos, 2002). Leaders can experience many issues which cause their minds and bodies to be stressed. Although women continue to be underrepresented in leadership roles, they continue to be responsible for maintaining their households and attending to dependents (Turnbow, 2019). Goodwin (2019) asserts women are known for having two or more statuses beyond work including, being mothers, wives, caretakers, friends, sisters, and aunts, including being activists or advocates in their communities and religious organizations. These various responsibilities contribute to women experiencing more work history interruptions (Brawner et al., 2020; Kleihauer et al., 2013). Additionally, these circumstances may result in women receiving less leadership training than men, which may cause women to feel less confident and not as comfortable in seeking leadership positions (Brawner et al., 2020).

Ekine (2018) contends women are less likely to hold positions of leadership in universities. This trend is possibly due to women being perceived as less assertive in their abilities, personality traits, self-confidence, aspirations, and confidence in their leadership abilities (Brawner et al., 2020; Ekine, 2018). The stress of the dual role of women in academic leadership as wives and mothers also discourages women from remaining in these positions (Ekine, 2018; Goodwin, 2019). Men in these positions can relax and unwind without the stresses of domestic chores and the responsibility of caring for children (Brawner et al., 2020; Ekine, 2018). Fewer women in these leadership positions reduces the number of mentors available to Black women (Ekine, 2018). Additionally, there is a lack of mentoring groups for Black women,

and they tend to be less involved in informal networks; more often, senior leaders in administration are men who leave women to fend for themselves (Ekine, 2018). Mentoring is crucial in developing visionary leaders in higher education institutions (Iheduru-Aderson & Shingles, 2023). Although Black women can be mentored by men, it is more beneficial for women to have other Black women mentors; Black women interacting, sharing experiences and knowledge, is significant to their career growth (Ekine, 2018).

Black women in higher education leadership positions often experience more stress related to the many difficulties and pressures they feel while working and functioning in higher education institutions. Some of these stress factors include job demands such as an increased workload and overtime (Davis & Brown, 2017; Eagan Jr. & Garvey, 2015; Gray & Brooks, 2021; Griffin et al., 2011; Harley, 2008; Taylor, 2005). They tend to receive substandard rewards, including lower job security and lower salary (Cole & Secret, 2012; Davis & Brown, 2017). In addition, their work-family balance causes stress, from the demands of cooking, taking care of children, and fulfilling other household needs (Cole & Secret, 2012; Golden, 2020; Harley, 2008). Most importantly, Black women experience discrimination, which includes both racism and sexism (Eagan Jr. & Garvey, 2015). Stress in higher education institutions creates consequences for the entire institution. These consequences include loss of faculty and senior-level administrators, work burnouts, decreased job performances, racial tension, and sexist experiences on Black women in leadership positions. Unfortunately, these women tend to have diminished physical and mental health. These kinds of encounters make it increasingly difficult for Black women to maintain their success in higher education institutions while navigating senior leadership positions.

Background of Study

Historically, Black women have been underrepresented in senior leadership positions in higher education (Alexander, 2010; Barkhuizen et al., 2022; Golden, 2020; Turnbow, 2019). This underrepresentation in senior leadership for Black women, has the potential to create a misrepresentation of Black women in higher education institutions. According to the American Council on Education (2023), the longstanding gender gap in higher education remains wide, and it is of deep concern for the higher education community at large. The percentage of women in leadership roles has seen a slight increase of just under 10% since 2006 (ACE, 2023). Additionally, many of the women presidents were White women, considering women of color only represented 5.1% of college presidents in 2016 (ACE, 2023).

The inadequate number of Black women leaders in higher education supports the continued exploration to position and cultivate Black women for ascension into key leadership roles while creating diversity in higher education (Alexander, 2010; Barkhuizen et al., 2022). The minimal number of representatives contributes to the stress of Black women in leadership feeling pressure to represent and lead for all the other Black women. By developing deeper insight into the experiences of Black women, presidents, institutions, boards, search committees, and search firms can work to remove barriers Black women face in their progression to senior leadership positions (ACE, 2023).

Senior leadership positions in higher education require leaders to constantly engage with their environment, individuals, and groups at the institution (Fitzgerald, 2020; Lamin, 2023). This constant interaction can increase stress in these positions, which is a result of interactions and relationships individuals have with or within their environment (Michalidas & Asimenos, 2002; Slaymaker et al., 2022). Studies have identified specific psychosocial stressors within

academic working conditions, including work overload, role insufficiency, decrease in autonomy and control, excessive administrative responsibilities, and poor communication within the workplace (Barksdale, 2007; Gillespie et al., 2001; Golden, 2020; Springer et al., 2023). The effects of stress for individuals can be physical, behavioral, or mental. The health issues can include hypertension, heart disease, increased smoking and drinking, anger, less involvement in family, or marital issues, which lead to increased staff turnover and absenteeism (Burke et al., 2023; Essix, 2014; Johnson et al., 2022). These physical, behavioral, and mental stressors can reduce the tenure of an administrator in a senior leadership position in higher education.

Although women and men experience stress, Black women are a unique group that is often invisible in the research. Black women in leadership positions in higher education experience a higher amount of stress compared to men and White women due to feeling obligated to pursue additional duties in their positions because of the double bind of race and gender (Davis & Brown, 2017; Eagan Jr. & Garvey, 2015; Gray & Brooks, 2021; Griffin et al., 2011; Harley, 2008; Taylor, 2005). The intersectionality of race and gender causes a unique experience because White women and Black men both have dominant characteristics that are irrelevant in Black women. Black women leaders often feel obligated to increase their workload by serving on diversity, academic, and professional committees while mentoring students of color to fit in with their White and male colleagues (Eagan Jr. & Garvey, 2015; Gray & Brooks, 2021; Harley, 2008). Research conducted by Dorenkamp and Weiß (2018) confirms women leaders over commit which intensifies strain at a higher rate than men; however, the research focuses more on White women and leaves room for speculation regarding Black women. Additionally, these increased tasks often lead to increased stress and fatigue for these

professional women (Davis & Brown, 2017). The purpose of this study is to understand how black women senior leaders in higher education manage stress.

Problem Statement

Black women have had to overcome traumas originating from slavery, violence, and rape succeeded by institutional and structural discrimination, racism, and oppression (Chance, 2021). The intersectionality of systematic racism and sexism creates additional challenges for Black women generating stressful situations for these women (Commodore et al., 2018; Young & Anderson, 2021). Challenges can affect one sex more than the other, especially when a person is not able to reap the benefits of social constructs such as White and male privilege (Chance, 2021). The research has indicated that stress among Black women leaders can affect productivity in higher education through high turnover rates, the inability to produce high quality work, reduced research productivity, and personal effects on these women including burnout, physical and mental health issues, and substance abuse (Agbonluae et al., 2017; Gillespie et al., 2001; Michailidis & Asimenos, 2002; Stickley & Scott, 2016; Wells, 2013). The extreme pressure of stress Black women face causes them to seek ways to cope to avoid demonstrating weakness or vulnerability, which can lead to unhealthy coping mechanisms such as excessive drinking and binge eating (Barksdale, 2007; Golden, 2020). Prolonged exposure to stress increases the rates of hypertension, heart disease, and substance abuse due to increased levels of frustration, anger, and resentment (Golden, 2020).

Stress is an overarching problem that affects many people in leadership positions in higher education institutions; however, there is a paucity of research related to the ways that Black women in senior leadership positions manage stress. Without ways to manage stressors, burnout becomes a prolonged response due to unrealistic and excessive demands which create

exhaustion, feelings of cynicism and detachment from the job, and feelings of ineffectiveness, and a lack of accomplishment (Turnbow, 2019). Black women in higher education face many challenges, such as managing multiple roles and work-life conflict (Banks, 2022). Consequently, there is an abundance of research discussing the types of stress Black women experience and how those stressors affect the overall productivity of institutions and the individual. However, the research is scarce when it comes to developing approaches for Black leaders to manage this stress. Thus, it is important to analyze how stress in Black women leaders impacts the organization and governance of the institution. Stress for this marginalized group of women can affect the decision-making process, leadership decisions, and equitable practices in higher education institutions. Given the abundance of research identifying the stress related to Black women leaders, it is essential to increase research related to Black women leaders managing this stress in higher education institutions.

Purpose

The purpose of this study is to understand how Black women senior leaders in higher education manage stress. Black women senior leaders in higher education have many obstacles they deal with which causes stress while also navigating their careers in higher education, including experiencing discrimination in the workplace, balancing work and household demands, increasing work responsibilities compared to men and White women, and lacking resources to navigate these disparities (Davis & Brown, 2017; Eagan Jr., 2015; Gray & Brooks, 2021; Harley, 2008). More research is needed to identify strategies, resources, or policies in higher education institutions which Black women leaders in higher education can follow to eliminate the disparities in senior leadership positions. The qualitative, phenomenological nature of this study

will provide higher education institutions insight from Black women leaders' perspective as it relates to their own experiences in higher education in senior leadership positions.

Research Question

The following research question was developed to frame this study to assist Black women aspiring to become leaders in senior-level Student Affairs positions in higher education understand and prepare for the possible stressors they may encounter while in these positions.

1. How do Black women in senior-level Student Affairs roles including, Vice Presidents, Deans, Associate Deans, and Directors manage the effects of stress in their current leadership roles in two-year higher education institutions?

Significance

Black women experience an increased amount of stress in leadership positions compared to men and White women in higher education institutions (Alexander, 2010). This research will shed light on the issue pertaining to disproportionate stress experienced by Black women senior leaders in higher education and determine ways to assist them on their ascension to senior leadership positions while also offering institutions insight in understanding these issues while determining strategies to reduce the problem. According to the American College President Study in ACE (2023), there has been less than a ten percent increase in the representation of Black women in senior leadership roles in higher education since 2006. Understanding the reasons for only a minor increase in the number of Black women in senior leadership roles will assist in establishing solutions to increase the representation of Black women in senior leadership positions.

Definition of Terms

The following terms have been operationalized for the context of this study:

Black women: Throughout this study Black women is referenced to distinguish from women of color and White women, however, when this study references Black women, it is implied to include "females who identify as Negro, Black, African, African American, and Afro Caribbean" (Banks, 2022, p. 17).

Senior-Level Administrators in Higher Education: For the purpose of this research, senior-level administrators will include the titles typically included in Student Affairs Leadership roles. These roles include vice presidents, deans, associate deans, and directors.

Higher Education Institutions: This term includes institutions who provide post-secondary education including four-year institutions offering bachelor's and/or master's level degrees, certificates, and community colleges offering two-year degrees.

Stress: Stress is defined as a response to circumstances and situations that inflict increased demands on a person which result in negative consequences (Michailidis and Asimenos, 2002).

Organization of Study

The organization of this study will consist of five chapters. Chapter one provides an overview of the study, background, problem statement, purpose of the research, research question, significance of the study, and definition of significant terms. Chapter two discusses a review of related literature. Chapter three describes the methodology by which the data was collected, analyzed, and reported. The discovery of the findings of the study will be featured in

chapter four. Chapter five delivers implications of the findings for policy, practice, and future research.

Chapter Two: Literature Review

Introduction

The primary purpose of this study was to understand how Black women in Student Affairs senior leadership roles in higher education manage stress. Additionally, this study aimed to understand the stress Black women deal with while in these positions to allow institutions to develop processes to reduce the amount of stress Black women experience in higher education institutions while in senior leadership positions. Lastly, this study strives to contribute to the literature regarding Black women managing stress to ascend to more senior leadership positions in higher education.

Stress

Stress can emanate from the many difficulties and pressures felt while working in high level positions within higher education institutions. Stress is defined as the result of an unspecified reaction of the body to physiological or psychological demands and pressures the environment exerts on an individual (Gilgorovski et al., 2018; Michailidis & Asimenos, 2002; Schwanzer et al., 2022). According to Bauman et al. (2023), organizations have recurring stressors including high work demands, emotional burdens, lack of appreciation, and work-family conflict. Due to these challenges, the leadership roles Black women have obtained over the years may exacerbate the stress felt while working in higher education. Prior to discussing the effects of stress, it is important to review the literature which includes leadership, causes of stress, Black women and stress, personal effects of stress, and the effects of stress on higher education institutions and organizational governance.

Causes of Stress

There are many factors which contribute to stress, which will be identified to allow individuals to better identify and manage stressors. Individuals experience stress anytime they may need to adjust to an environment consisting of unappealing events such as work pressure, marital problems, or financial problems (Michailidis & Asimenos, 2002; Slaymaker, 2020; Stickle & Scott, 2016). Stress has been studied widely throughout the years; however, minimal research has been completed to identify stress factors influencing individual and organizational performance within the context of higher education institutions (Michailidis & Asimenos, 2002; Slaymaker, 2020). Examining the effects of stress on Black women in leadership roles in higher education can help institutions address these stressors, support Black women's well-being, and sustain their valuable contributions to institutional strength.

Work Obligations

Stress has become a growing phenomenon in higher education institutions, especially with the changes which have taken place due to global factors, such as curriculum designs, additional responsibilities due to a shortage of staff able to work, and high-performance expectation (Yousefi & Abdullah, 2019). Stress factors include job demands such as an increased workload and overtime; substandard rewards, including lower job security and lower salary than men and White women; and work-family conflict stress, which includes demands of cooking, taking care of children, and fulfilling other household needs (Davis & Brown, 2017; Eagan Jr., 2015; Gray & Brooks, 2021). Moreover, stress is related to a decrease in job performance and negative work attitudes which cause a reduction in motivation (Gligorovski et al., 2018; Schat & Frone, 2011).

Mental Health Challenges

Stress causes declines in health and well-being that reduce the ability to perform at work (Gligorovski et al., 2018; Schat & Frone, 2011). Health challenges not only affect an individual's lifespan, but they can also cause the employee to work less and produce only the minimum amount of work due (Slaymaker, 2020). It is important to note that stress can be associated with events that may be pleasant and unpleasant; consequently, stress is only problematic when it remains unresolved (Erkutlu et al., 2011). Unresolved stress can cause individuals to become disorganized, disoriented, and less able to cope, causing additional health problems (Erkutlu et al., 2011). Work-related stress is indicated in chronic fatigue, which can cause temporary or permanent inability to work, deterioration of the quality of life, and the effectiveness and safety at work (Springer et al., 2023). In addition to causing disease, chronic fatigue can cause irritability, depression, aggressiveness, and sleep disturbances (Springer et al., 2023). The mental health of Black women senior leaders is impacted by stress linked to the Strong Black Woman (SBW) image, which portrays them as unbreakable, able to endure difficulties without harm, and defines them as having unwavering strength (Graham et al., 2020).

This image causes women to compromise sleep, health, and personal wellness to achieve goals while additionally feeling obligated to assist others (Graham et al., 2020). Recognizing unresolved stress allows an institution or organization a chance to anticipate problems and determine potential solutions. Therefore, it would be beneficial for institutions to invest in professional development training to address stress experienced by senior-level administrators (Slaymaker, 2020).

Effects on the Organization

Since the research on stress and its devastating effects are so prominent, institutions should be interested in determining if workplace stress has the potential to derail an institution's growth. Although stress within the workplace has been recognized, little attention has been given to the problem (Erkutlu et al., 2011; Yousef & Abdullah, 2019). Stress has a negative impact on the degree of satisfaction with employee's achievement, value, and growth (Michailidis & Asimenos, 2011; Yaman & Yaman, 2023). Determining whether employee satisfaction can exist under conditions of rampant stress is critical. Aggressive work cultures and performance pressures foster work-related stress that manifests in outcomes such as burnout, absenteeism, high turnover, and reduced motivation (Yousef & Abdullah, 2019; Michailidis & Asimenos, 2002; Yaman & Yaman, 2023). To reduce stress within higher education institutions, administrators and college boards must consider the importance of institutions hiring and providing training for qualified leaders to manage employee stress to increase employee satisfaction.

Black Women and Stress

Black women in senior leadership positions have many causes of stress which their male counterparts are less likely to experience in a higher education setting. Black women have the double bind of discrimination, which includes both racism and sexism (Lamin, 2023; Slay, 2023). Black women combined experiences of racial and gender discrimination impacts health outcomes and life expectancy (Slay, 2023). Research shows there are many causes of stress for Black women in senior leadership positions including job demands, substandard rewards received by Black women, work-family conflict stress, and discrimination (Bauman et al., 2023; Cole & Secret, 2012; Davis & Brown, 2017; Eagan Jr. & Garvey, 2015; Golden, 2020; Gray &

Brooks, 2021; Griffin et al., 2011; Harley, 2008; Taylor, 2005). Black women leaders experience mental and physical effects of stress including burnout, depression, hypertension, and cardiovascular disease (Golden, 2020). Stress also causes personal effects on Black women in leadership positions, such as diminished physical and mental health. These areas make it increasingly difficult for Black women leaders to maintain their success in higher education institutions.

Black women are exposed to exclusion due to lack of participation in organizational decision making, less access to informal and social networks, and inadequate opportunities for promotion to administrative and tenure positions (Cole & Secret, 2012). These experiences leave Black women fighting to prove their worth, disprove automatic neglects, and resist the internalization of automatic neglects (Davis & Brown, 2017). Unfortunately, Black women are three times more likely to be dissatisfied with their positions in higher education than both White women and Black men, due to feelings of invisibility or under-appreciation (Golden, 2020). According to Dorenkamp & Weiß (2018) improving the balance between effort and reward can help reduce turnover rates, decrease strain, and improve job satisfaction.

Job Demands

Demands of the job contribute to stress, especially for Black women in faculty and senior-level leadership positions. Golden (2020) suggests the workload for Blacks is usually more demanding than Whites, because of the added responsibilities related to establishing and reinforcing diversity and mentoring students of color. According to Cole and Secret (2012), “professional positions who experienced greater job demands were more likely to experience workplace stress” (p. 320). Black women are taught from a young age to be the best by giving 150%, because there is an expectation in the Black community to persevere despite the obstacles

and disparity they may face (Taylor, 2005). Black women in leadership positions feel overly obligated to pursue additional duties in their positions because of the double bind of gender and race (Davis & Brown, 2017; Eagan Jr. & Garvey, 2015; Gray & Brooks, 2021; Griffin et al., 2011; Harley, 2008; Taylor, 2005). Black women leaders often feel obligated to increase their workload by serving on diversity committees, mentoring students of color, and maintaining a sizeable teaching load (Eagan Jr. & Garvey, 2015; Gray & Brooks, 2021; Harley, 2008) just to fit in with their White and male counterparts. Women also feel a greater burden to mentor students and serve their academic and professional communities compared to their male colleagues (Eagen Jr. & Garvey, 2015). Research conducted by Dorenkamp and Weiß (2018) confirms that over-commitment intensifies strain, and this over-commitment has a stronger effect on women than it does on their male colleagues. Also, these increased tasks often lead to increased stress and fatigue for these professional women (Davis & Brown, 2017). According to Davis and Brown (2017), these increased tasks result in invisibility because their contributions and suggestions are unacknowledged, reminding these educators that it is not their engagement in the work that matters, but the representation of the institution to keep up the appearance of diversity and inclusion. Job related burdens may make it more difficult for Black women to cope with the experiences and challenges of daily life, creating stressful situations which may threaten their emotional well-being (Cole & Secret, 2012). It is also interesting to note that although most institutions offer benefit options, such as flex time, less than ten percent of Black women take advantage of this additional benefit (Cole & Secret, 2012). This tendency is possibly due to being taught from a young age to give 150% regardless of the possible struggle it causes. Despite the increased tasks of Black women, they still receive substandard rewards.

Substandard Rewards

Unfortunately, Black women are not rewarded according to the amount of work they perform. These substandard rewards often include lower salaries than men and White women in the same field and with decreased responsibility than their colleagues (Chance, 2021; Cole & Secret, 2012; Hagan & Oliver, 2022). Due to these substandard rewards, Black women in leadership positions may feel underappreciated and overworked. "Black female faculty are often asked to take on more tasks and responsibilities for less pay" (Davis & Brown, 2017, p. 6). Many women in higher education hold prestigious job titles without the power, job authority, and while often being undercompensated, particularly with lower earnings relative to their credentials than White women and Black men (Chance, 2021; Cole & Secret, 2012). Black women who are affected by low job demands and low salary experience increased stress and the possibility of separating from their higher education careers (Dorenkamp & Weiß, 2018). "Black women are contending with many issues that are preventing the same success enjoyed by other faculty to prove their worth, disprove stereotypes, and maintain the self-efficacy necessary to persist through the unconscious discounts that are pervasive" (Davis & Brown, 2017, p. 7). Although experts expect a shift in the pay of minority women due to the increased number of minorities and women in doctorate programs, Black men have more representation and greater access and opportunity in higher education leadership than Black women (Chance, 2021; Davis & Maldonado, 2015).

Work-Family Conflict

In addition to substandard rewards, Black women must also face stress stemming from work-family conflict. Black women in higher education report lower levels of job satisfaction than any other ethnic group due to lack of job satisfaction because of salary, rank/title, workload,

and support (Golden, 2020). Research regarding work-family connection has mostly concentrated on the White population; therefore, little is known about the ways in which Black women are affected by stress associated with work-family conflict (Cole & Secret, 2012). However, Black women are experiencing work-family conflict within higher education just as often as their White colleagues. This work-family conflict stress includes increased role conflict and household demand conflict (Golden, 2020).

Black women have many roles in society including, wife, mother, daughter, sister, community activist, church leader, and homemaker (Goodwin, 2019; Harley, 2008). Due to the many roles Black women play in society, they may experience role conflict which can contribute to the lack of overall job satisfaction (Golden, 2020). Roles such as mother, spouse, and employee held by Black women often collide and increase stress and overwhelming feelings of inadequacies (Golden, 2020). Despite the number of roles held by Black women in leadership positions, each one of them is equally as important as the next in their eyes. Fulfilling the necessary requirements for each of these roles is what Black women aspire to accomplish. Black women may not have access to flexible schedules to the same extent as White women which places them at an increased risk to experience work-family conflict stress (Cole & Secret, 2012; Erving et al., 2021). Black women often experience unique expectations and role conflict within their family environment compared to men and White women (Erving et al., 2021). Golden (2020) identifies eight areas in which role conflict most commonly occurs. These include time management, marital relationships, finances, household management, child-rearing, self-expectations, expectations of others, and guilt. While they are committed to their organizations, these women still need to fulfill childcare demands, which women face more than men, and community and religious demands (Cole & Secret, 2012; Erving et al., 2021). Because of these

family aspects, Black women experience more work-family conflict stress and are reluctant to inform their superiors of the conflicts associated with this type of stress (Cole & Secret, 2012).

There are three demographic variables associated with increased work-family conflict stress, having children in the home, being married, and having a professional position with increased job demands (Cole & Secret, 2012; Slaymaker, 2020). Black women higher education professionals experience increased amounts of stress in the areas of promotions because of time constraints and home responsibilities, which include household chores, childcare, children's problems, and marital conflict (Eagan Jr. & Garvey, 2015; Harley, 2008). Golden (2020) suggests child-rearing and parenting, marriage or partnerships, and a lack of understanding regarding the expectations of the positions resulting in Black women leaving their higher education positions. Eagan Jr. and Garvey (2015) state work-family stress can have an impact on personal and professional outcomes for women, and their academic careers can be affected by family changes. The structure of academia does not accommodate higher education professionals with children. Black women may often feel targeted on issues related to work-life balance because women still fulfill traditional family roles, and this reality increases the stress of Black women senior leaders (Eagan Jr. & Garvey, 2015). Recently, more than ever, Black women professionals in higher education were challenged with balancing work-family stress during the Covid-19 pandemic (Gray & Brooks, 2021). "They have been tasked with doing their work from home, while homeschooling their own children online, managing the household chores, ordering or procuring groceries, addressing the emotional needs of children who have not seen their friends in months and cannot go anywhere, all while preventing and reducing anxiety and fear in everyone around them, including themselves" (Gray & Brooks, 2021, p. 4). In addition to the challenges

associated with household demands, Black women also experience stress related to their personal and physical health.

Personal Effects of Stress

Black women in predominately White institutions suffer from race fatigue, the syndrome of being over extended, undervalued, unappreciated and knowing the person will be asked to represent his or her race in even more capacity (Harley, 2008). The extreme pressure of stress Black women face causes them to find acceptable ways to cope with stress that does not demonstrate weakness or vulnerability (Barksdale, 2007; Golden, 2020). This issue can cause unhealthy coping mechanisms such as excessive drinking and binge eating which contributes to obesity and cardiovascular disease (Golden, 2020). Prolonged exposure to stress can also result in increased levels of frustration, anger, and resentment which increases the rates of hypertension, heart disease, and substance abuse (Golden, 2020).

High levels of stress can also impact the ability to organize and produce high quality work and is related to absenteeism and retention issues (Golden, 2020). Stress in higher education has been correlated with other physical health issues such as, migraines, insomnia, pain in back and neck area, muscle tension, skin issues, and lowered immunity to viruses (Cole & Secret, 2012; Golden, 2020). The psychological outcomes of stress include depression, forgetfulness, burnout, anxiety, and increased frustration towards self, faculty, and staff (Baumann et al., 2023; Golden, 2020). In addition to all of these issues, Black women can also face issues such as discrimination.

Racial Discrimination

Discrimination is still a major issue Black women in higher education institutions are navigating daily, and they must be able to address discriminatory practices (Davis & Brown,

2017). Although there are many forms of discrimination, the research points to two forms of discrimination which increase stress for Black women in higher education institutions: racism and sexism. Additionally, this research focuses mostly on Black women faculty as opposed to senior-level leaders in Student Affairs. Due to the gap in the research, it will be beneficial to continue to explore the discrimination experienced by Black women Student Affairs leaders. According to Eagan Jr. and Garvey (2015), the number of faculty of color is steadily increasing; however, faculty of color still only account for less than 20% of all faculty. Although the number of Black women in higher education has increased, they remain largely outnumbered by male and White female faculty (Davis & Maldonado, 2015). In addition to this underrepresentation of Black women in higher education, faculty of color often feel greater stress due to subtle discrimination, which is correlated with reduced research productivity (Eagan Jr. & Garvey, 2015). Eagan Jr. and Garvey (2015) also determined faculty service responsibilities are greater and more heavily expected for Black faculty than from their White peers, which they found disturbing, since the services of faculty of color are undervalued. Black women are not seen as talented and competent leaders, but as "Black" leaders who are special hires or in their position to meet affirmative action quotas (Harley, 2008; Turner et al., 2011).

The pressure of racism often leaves Black women feeling compelled to over-adjust and avoid mistakes. They may struggle to gain credibility from peers, become more isolated and peripheral, face harmful stereotypes, and experience heightened stress (Turner et al., 2011). West (2019) noted Black administrators are marginalized and were not provided the support they needed to effectively complete their jobs. The consequences related to these pressures included feelings of isolation and lack of respect, being overused by the institutions, and disconnection from family and community commitment and their career (West, 2019). Unfortunately, racism is

not the only form of discrimination Black women face in higher education institutions. These women must deal with gender discrimination as well. Racism cannot be discussed without introducing the intersectionality of being Black and a woman.

Gender Discrimination

Although Black women face the intersectionality of race and gender, also referred to as the "double bind," they are usually forced to dedicate their position to only one cause, either race or gender (Davis & Brown, 2017). Marginalization is exacerbated when considering both social identities of being Black and a woman and the difficulties associated due to lack of community (Davis & Brown, 2017; Eagan Jr. & Garvey, 2015). Black women also experience a lack of respect from students who often question their credentials and teaching skills in the classroom (Davis & Brown, 2017; Eagan Jr. & Garvey, 2015). Black women are also more prone to have their research trivialized than men, have heavier teaching loads, and devote more time to teaching related involvements (Eagan Jr. & Garvey, 2015). Additionally, Black women who voice their opinions about issues are labeled as troublemakers (Harley, 2008). They are also reprimanded more often by their dean and criticized more often by colleagues (Harley, 2008). This lack of respect causes Black women to feel isolated and unappreciated causing additional stress and desires to leave higher education institutions.

Black women can attempt to defend themselves by speaking against the marginalization, tokenization, and isolation, but often run the risk of being labeled as the "angry Black woman" when their voices are used to express dissent on an issue (Davis & Brown, 2017). According to a study completed by Golden (2020), it is difficult to discuss anything adverse for Black women, because the narrative of a strong Black woman can shift easily to angry Black woman. Additionally, the women interviewed expressed concern for needing to be strong to manage

issues, but as Black women, they are not allowed to be assertive, passionate, or vocal without being labeled as angry or bitter (Golden, 2020). Because of these issues strong Black women have an increased amount of stress in higher education (Golden, 2020). Examining how stress can negatively affect Black women leaders is important to study how stress also impacts the institution's organizational governance.

Effects of Stress in Higher Education Institution and Organizational Governance

Organization and governance related to decision-making, leadership, and equitable practices in higher education are also important factors to discuss in connection to how stress related factors may cause a strain in these practices. Stress in higher education institutions also creates consequences inside the institution. These consequences include loss of faculty and administrators due to burnout and job performance.

Stress can affect the institution as a whole, and it can also have personal effects on Black women in these institutions which includes loss of senior leaders due to burnout and job performance and the personal effects which include physical and mental health issues for Black women senior leaders (Golden, 2020; Yousef & Abdullah, 2019). When researching how stress can affect higher education, the research indicated ways in which stress can have a lasting effect on the institution. According to Harley (2008), the gap in the percentage of Black women in tenured positions and men in tenured positions has not changed in thirty years. It is extremely important for higher education institutions to retain Black women in these leadership positions because of the losses these institutions will experience when Black women leaders decide to separate from the institution attributable to the effects of stress.

Stress in Black women in higher education has been related to burnout, turnover rates, low job performance, and reduced levels of commitment to the institution (Golden, 2020). In a

study conducted by Eagan Jr. and Garvey (2015), increased stress levels due to discrimination noticeably correlated with reduced research productivity by Black men and women. Within this research, subtle discrimination represented a hindrance stressor which diminishes from faculty's ability to focus on their work (Eagan Jr. & Garvey, 2015). This inclination can be extremely detrimental to research institutions who rely on research for their sustainability and development. Marginalizing of Black women faculty or devaluing their research depicts them as not being major contributors to the institution, and this racial bias carries over into the tenure process (Harley, 2008). This devaluation of Black faculty's research causes others in positions over the tenure process to make assumptions and poor decisions towards Black faculty. Additionally, this added stress can increase disadvantages for Black women faculty when seeking promotions (Eagan Jr. & Garvey, 2015). Added disadvantages for Black women faculty creates segregation, marginalization, and academic apartheid which can cause lawsuits related to discrimination to be filed against the institution (Harley, 2008).

Stress experienced by Black women in leadership positions can affect the decision-making process, leadership decisions, and equitable practices in higher education institutions. Black women in leadership positions become more reluctant to make decisions or question the decisions they make regarding the institutions, because they can retreat into isolation due to lack of respect or feelings of their credibility being questioned (West, 2019). Black women also experience tokenism when trying to make meaningful contributions to the university and having their suggestions to go unacknowledged (Davis & Brown, 2017). In addition, Black women faculty are more likely to have their authority and credentials challenged by students in the classroom which is less likely to happen for male faculty (Davis & Brown, 2017; Eagan Jr. & Garvey, 2015). When this discrimination occurs, it can cause Black women leaders to feel

dispensable in the profession. This discouraging feeling makes the decision-making process exhausting for Black women in leadership positions in higher education institutions. It is important within this research to determine how these faculty issues correlate with senior leadership positions in Student Affairs.

When Black women have a tougher time making decisions due to stress within the decision-making process, institutions must question whether the leadership selections being made are the best choices for the institution. When leaders are making decisions in stressful situations, they may seek these options to accommodate their work-family conflict as opposed to making the best decision for the institution. A study conducted by Cole and Secret (2012) determined that 68% of the Black women respondents were in management or professional positions and utilized constraints within their positions. Although these women utilized constraints, how are we to know these methods will be used by others in leadership positions when making decisions? It would be extremely beneficial for future research to be completed to determine how leadership decisions made by Black women would be improved with reduced amounts of stress within higher education institutions.

Equitable practices in higher education institutions are a difficult concept to identify especially when Black women are continuously experiencing racism and sexism in higher education institutions today. Black women are often ignored when trying to contribute to the university, reminding them that their engagement in the workplace does not matter, but what does matter is their representation with the university to maintain the appearance of diversity and inclusion (Davis & Brown, 2017). It is disheartening to study the number of questionable acts experienced by Black women in leadership positions in higher education institutions and have the institution claim diversity and inclusion. According to Davis and Brown (2017), when both

social identities of Black women are considered, there are alarmingly lower numbers of Black female faculty in higher education institutions. Because of these low numbers, the challenges these women encounter are exacerbated due to the lack of community (Davis & Brown, 2017). Without Black women senior leaders, the institution reduces their diversity and inclusion affiliation. If higher education institutions continue to practice inequitable decision-making practices, they will continue to lose qualified Black women senior leaders.

Leadership

Leadership is an important part of our day-to-day lives, especially in our careers. Becoming a leader can be difficult and create many different feelings including anxiety and stress for both the leader and the follower. Literature related to leadership and stress addresses the deleterious outcomes related to increased levels of chronic stress (Slaymaker et al., 2022). When leaders are stressed, it can affect their followers' work performance. Stress has cost organizations $200 billion dollars a year through workplace accidents, absenteeism, turnovers, increased health care costs and a decrease in quantity and quality of production; however, research indicates stress can be reduced by practicing strategies such as mindfulness to promote personal well-being to increase effective leadership (Slaymaker et al., 2022; Stickle & Scott, 2016). This revelation makes it important to understand how to manage these issues before they overwhelm both the leader and the follower. Learning how to manage stress early is especially important for new leaders who are seeking advancement in their careers to avoid followers' performance issues.

Organizations choose people to have different roles within the organization. One of the many roles vital to an organization is that of leadership. Leaders are essential parts of institutions, and these leaders are followers of these institutions which encompass the system

(Gardner, 2010). Leadership is the process of influencing a group to pursue objectives held by the leader or shared by the institution (Gardner, 2010). According to Northouse (2016), leaders tap into the motives of followers to better reach the goals of both the leader and the follower. Leadership is a key factor to ensuring the success of an organization (Wen et al., 2019). There are many different types of leadership skills which would be useful in developing the type of followership leaders need, but for the purpose of this research the focus will be transformational leadership.

Transformational Leadership

Many leaders are accustomed to a transactional leadership style which consists of a promise of reward for good behavior or threats and discipline for negative behavior (Bass, 2010). This leadership style is not conducive to leading followers in organizations today, because transactional leadership produces mediocrity (Bass, 2010). Leaders who use transactional leadership styles are less involved in the follower's performance and usually only offer criticism when tasks are not completed or done sufficiently. To circumvent this problem, it would be beneficial for the leader to develop a leadership style which complements the employee. Transformational leadership is one such leadership style which inspirationally motivates, intellectually stimulates, influences ideas, and practices individualized consideration (Arnold et al., 2017). "Superior leadership performance – transformational leadership – occurs when leaders broaden and elevate the interests of their employees, when they generate awareness and acceptance of the purposes and mission of the group, and when they stir their employees to look beyond their own self-interest for the good of the group" (Bass, 2010, pp. 257–258). Northouse (2016) sums up transformational leadership in the following passage:

> As its name implies, transformational leadership is a process that changes and transforms people. It is concerned with emotions, values, ethics, standards, and long-term goals. It includes assessing followers' motives, satisfying their needs, and treating them as full human beings. Transformational leadership involves an exceptional form of influence that moves followers to accomplish more than is usually expected of them. It is a process that often incorporates charismatic and visionary leadership (p.161).

To achieve these results, transformational leaders inspire employees by being charismatic, meeting the emotional needs of their employees, sympathizing with issues of personal and organizational stress, stimulating these employees intellectually, and providing individualized consideration to these followers (Bass, 2010). According to Bass (2010), transformational leaders are referred to as effective leaders by colleagues and employees compared to those who practice transactional leadership. One of the main characteristics of transformational leadership is individualized consideration. Individualized consideration entails mentoring others while practicing empathy (McClellan et al., 2017). Providing fundamental motivation and follower development fits the needs of work groups who desire to be inspired and empowered to succeed (Northouse, 2016). Leaders can demonstrate empathy, provide support, encouragement, and coaching while also setting challenging goals specific to the individual's needs. Based on this literature, transformational leadership would be an effective leadership style to cope with stress because it would provide relief for both the leader and the follower (McClellan et al., 2017).

Effective leaders set the tone for followers through thoughts and feelings (Darling & Heller, 2011). They should be mindful to not force leader-imposed stress upon followers (Stickle & Scott, 2016). These leaders should be creative and positive when responding to negative issues or actions and emit positive responses to their followers through the law of attraction (Darling &

Heller, 2011). Conversely, when a leader is negative, he or she will attract negative thoughts and actions from followers (Darling & Heller, 2011). Therefore, it is important for leaders to emulate charisma through transformational leadership so followers will positively respond to the needs of the organization. Once a leader is aware of the possible contribution to organizational stress, he or she can assist employees with techniques to reduce stress in the workplace (Stickle & Scott, 2016). Darling and Heller (2011) shared 12 guidelines which can assist a charismatic leader to address stress within him or herself and assist employees to contend with potentially stressful situations. These 12 guidelines include recognizing and reviewing the primary purpose in life, reviewing the nature of their thoughts and feelings, monitoring warning signals (low energy, excessive worrying, nervousness), identifying causes of possible stress, prioritizing and managing their time, being concerned only about matters they have control over, being healthy, relaxing, developing supportive relationships, keeping difficulties in perspective, and identifying a purpose in major events within the organization (Stickle & Scott, 2016). Leaders who are effective continuously monitor the changes within themselves by searching for opportunities to learn more about their personal strength and how their personal and professional growth can impact follower's performance (Boyatzis & McKee, 2005). Knowing themselves will require leaders to reflect. Pipe and Bortz (2009) present questions leaders should reflect on to learn more about their personal characteristics and leadership qualities. These questions include, How do I feel cared for?; How do I express my care for others?; What are the triggers that I am not feeling nurtured?; How do I replenish myself?; How does self-replenishment relate to the leadership service of others?; What makes me happy?; What are my personal rituals for letting go of work/obligations at the end of the day?; Am I growing?; and Am I helping others to grow professionally?" (Pipe & Bortz, 2009, p. 36). Reflecting on these questions will help leaders to

begin the process of self-discovery and later assist followers to create an environment of self-discovery and meaning (Pipe & Bortz, 2009). Although these techniques related to transformational leadership focus on a reduction of stress for followers, this research aims to determine if these same techniques could be utilized by Black women in administrative positions to manage their own stress.

Theoretical Framework

Theoretical frameworks are utilized to recount concepts and theories which are refined from previously tested and published knowledge used to assist with advancing a basis to analyze and interpret the meaning contained in the research (Kivunja, 2018). Due to the complexity of the research subject Managing Stress in Black women in Higher Education Institutions, there are multiple theoretical frameworks which would assist with managing how Black women manage stress; however, Black Feminist Thought (BFT) and Strong Black Woman Collective (SBWC), were the categories for this research.

Black Feminist Thought

Black women are minorities in two regards, due to their sex and their race. Black Feminist Thought (BFT) frames the experiences these women encounter daily when dealing with stress in senior leadership positions in higher education. Oppression is not the only concern of BFT; additionally, BFT is concerned with resistance, activism, and politics of empowerment (Minoo, 2015). Gendered oppression compounds the racial discrimination Black women encounter daily (Davis, 2018). BFT highlights the relationship between power and knowledge, while questioning the idea of objective knowledge and neutral spaces (Minoo, 2015). Black women not only want to manage stress in leadership positions in higher education, but they also want a safe space in academia to be free from judgement and stereotypes. According to Davis

(2018), BFT portrays as self-described women whose cognizant understanding of their own perspective operates as a tool of defiance against the dehumanization of Black womanhood. Additionally, BFT supports women-centered analysis since this approach helps define Black women's viewpoints and offers knowledge regarding Black womanhood and may reveal how this group of women can be empowered (Davis, 2018). Empowerment of women is important to this research because it allows Black women to determine their voice within academia while navigating difficult spaces. BFT consists of expert thought created by Black women which details a standpoint of and for Black women (Quaye et al., 2023). BFT enhances the complex interaction between oppression, consciousness, and activism of Black women (West, 2019). According to Quaye et al. (2023), there are no singular tendencies to BFT; however, they highlight six differentiating features which characterizes BFT. First, considering Black women exist in a society where White people and Black men degrade them, they share an experience of struggling against racism and sexism (Quaye et al., 2023). Secondly, although BFT contains core themes, Black women differ in their responses to these core themes because their class, sexuality, and social identities cause them to navigate these systems differently (Quaye et al., 2023). The third dimension is the interdependence of experience and consciousness, which means that merely identifying as a Black woman does not mean she automatically develops distinctive group consciousness (Quaye et al., 2023). The fourth dimension is awareness and striving for a self-defined perspective which dominate groups have a vested interest in suppressing (Quaye et al., 2023). The fifth dimension is the correlation of thought and action; this dimension is the result of a BFT put into action to procure change (Quaye et al., 2023). The final dimension relates to the connection between BFT and other social justice efforts such as xenophobia (Quaye et al., 2023). These dimensions highlight the areas in which BFT will clarify the research related

to managing stress in Black women. Due to the pressures associated with Critical Race Theory (CRT) and BFT, the Strong Black Woman Collective (SBWC) may also contribute to the overall negative pressures associated with Black women in higher education institutions.

Strong Black Woman Collective

The Strong Black Woman (SBW) ideal is a long-established image of the Black woman which celebrates their strength, self-sufficiency, self-sacrificing, and resilience (Davis, 2015; Golden, 2020). The SBW ideal exacerbates the intersectionality of race and gender stressors compounded with being a Black woman (Golden, 2020). Additionally, according to Geyton et al. (2023), women with the SBW archetype support greater workloads without proper compensation, may refuse to seek assistance, and often prioritize organizational needs over their own self-care. The Strong Black Woman Collective (SBWC) advances the idea that Black women forge strength through shared communication practices by instilling their assembled voices with might and fortitude (Davis, 2015). However, this disposition can be problematic by preventing Black women from vocally sharing their emotions and vulnerability (Davis, 2015). SBWC obligates manifestations of strength and suppressions of emotions while also rejecting vulnerability and dependence upon others (Geyton et al., 2022). According to Davis (2015), there are four principles of the SBWC framework: (1) Black women communicate strength through specific communication practices, such as code switching, assertive communication, and direct verbal messages, and culturally nuanced speech codes; (2) the accumulation of Black women communicating strength comprises the SBWC; (3) members of the SBWC engage in the community by reinforcing the members' virtues of strength; and (4) communication patterns of strength allow the SBWC to confront and retreat from unfair constructs outside, but also impede vulnerability and emotionality within, the group. Studies conducted by Chance (2022) and

Graham et al. (2020) have utilized the SBW theory within their research. The research has shown how the SBWC contributes to the overall stress Black women may feel in higher education institutions.

Summary

Stress for Black women senior-level administrators is exacerbated by demands of the job, including workload and the number of hours worked in relation to men and White women. Black women also experience increased amounts of stress due to receiving substandard rewards such as lower salaries and decreased responsibility. The work-family dynamic for women senior-level leaders and faculty also increases the role conflict these women experience daily while also dealing with the double bind of racism and sexism in higher education institutions. Black women leaders additionally must deal with stereotypes such as strong Black woman shifting into the angry Black woman when defending themselves against racism and sexism. Stress associated with Black women can also affect the higher education institutions through loss of faculty and senior-level leaders, poor decisions during the tenure process, and possible lawsuits due to discriminatory processes. Physical and mental health issues of Black women are also affected when living with high levels of stress. These physical and mental health issues include depression, burnout, hypertension, and cardiovascular issues. SBWC was an essential aspect to frame the research to allow Black women to not only conquer oppression related to their sex and race but also become advocates and develop spaces for other Black women in academia. It is important for higher education institutions to reduce stress for Black women faculty and administrators. Organization and governance are highly affected by the stress Black women in leadership positions encounter in higher education institutions. Stress among this group can affect decision making in higher education, leadership, and equitable practices. When higher

education institutions begin to focus on reduction of stress in Black women, they will begin to have a happier, healthier, and more productive group of leaders.

Chapter Three: Methodology

Introduction

This research study aimed to explore the lived experiences of Black women in senior leadership positions in higher education including presidents, vice presidents, provosts, deans, and directors, and how they manage the effects of stress while in their leadership roles. This chapter will introduce the methodology of this qualitative phenomenological study to determine the volume of Black women in senior leadership positions who experience stress in their leadership roles within higher education institutions and how this stress is managed. Utilizing a phenomenological approach allowed the interviewees to provide meaningful insight of their lived experiences to identify phenomena of the stress related to their positions and what tools they utilized to manage the stress related to their positions (Barkhuizen, et al., 2022). A phenomenological lens also allowed the researcher to uncover the experiences of stress these women in these senior-level positions encounter within their positions and allow for underlying meanings of the participant's shared lived experiences to attain a deeper insight of the phenomenon of study (Barkhuizen et al., 2022; Chance, 2021). The research methodology for acquiring research participants, collecting and analyzing data, making ethical considerations, and testing reliability/validity are the main components of this section. The following research question was developed to frame this study to assist Black women aspiring to become leaders in senior-level leadership positions in higher education understand and prepare for the possible stressors they may encounter while in these positions: How do Black women in Senior level Student Affairs roles including, Vice Presidents, Provosts, Deans and Directors manage the effects of stress in their current leadership roles in two-year higher education institutions?

Research Methodology

The methodological approach the researcher uses is important to understanding the methodology to explore the experiences of Black women in senior-level leadership positions in Student Affairs to learn more about what may cause stress and discover ways to prevent stress among this group. According to Johnson and Christenson (2017), qualitative research focuses on particular people and places to learn about their world and experiences from their perspective.

Qualitative research is based on qualitative data which follows the exploratory mode of the scientific method such as phenomenology, ethnography, narrative inquiry, case study research, and grounded theory research (Johnson & Christenson, 2017). The results of qualitative research are dominantly presented through words from conducting interviews, observing settings, and analyzing the data by reviewing transcripts or field notes (Patten & Newhart, 2018). According to Patten and Newhart (2018), qualitative researchers frequently identify themes within the data.

Qualitative researchers plan inductively and take an exploratory approach to questions which have not been sufficiently identified (Patten & Newhart, 2018). This inductive reasoning approach provides probable reasoning; however, this reasoning is not conclusive (Johnson & Christenson, 2017). Additionally, within qualitative research, smaller samples are utilized to allow the researcher to spend more time with participants by conducting extended, in-depth, flexible one-on-one interviews, and thorough observations over time (Patten & Newhart, 2018). It is important to note that qualitative research allows for the possibility of adjusting, such as rewording or adding questions based on responses by participants (Patten & Newhart, 2018).

The purpose of the exploratory scientific method is to generate theory and understanding of particular people, places, and groups (Johnson & Christenson, 2017). The exploratory method

allows the researcher to make observations based on what was seen. The researcher then studies the observations for patterns and makes a provisionary conclusion or logical reasoning about the pattern (Johnson & Christenson, 2017). This method allows the researcher to generalize the findings (Patten & Newhart, 2018). Exploratory research is performed by conducting interviews to study the participants' attitudes, and to help better understand the situation (stress in leadership), its circumstances, and the characteristics of the social system. This method allows the researcher to utilize a bottom-up approach by moving from data to patterns to theory (Johnson & Christenson, 2017).

Research Design

The research design utilized for the research was exploratory.

Phenomenological Inquiry

The purpose of this study was to understand how Black women senior leaders in higher education manage stress, while allowing Black women to learn from these experiences and their impact on their leadership development as they advanced into senior leadership roles within higher education institutions. A phenomenological inquiry is the most appropriate methodology to use to understand the lived experiences of Black women in higher education senior leadership (Chance, 2021). According to Johnson and Christenson (2017), the purpose of phenomenological research is to obtain a view into the research participants' lives and to understand what their experiences mean to them. Within this design, the participants told stories of their lived experiences in senior leadership positions in higher education institutions through in-depth interviews (Johnson & Christenson, 2017). Phenomenological inquiry allows the researcher to explore the influence of stress, work obligations, mental health challenges, organizational challenges, job demands, substandard rewards, work-family conflict, and discrimination of

managing stress experiences of the participants (Chance, 2021). This approach allows the researcher to learn more about how participants' experiences affect their ascension to senior-level Student Affairs leadership positions in higher education. Designing the research in this manner allows the researcher to focus on actual experiences of women within the field and receive real stories aiming to highlight and resolve the problems in higher education institutions and initiate change.

Population

Asiamah et al. (2017) defines a research population as the group of individuals which have one or more characteristics of significance. As such, the research population for this study was Black women senior leaders in Student Affairs positions in higher education institutions. Participants were chosen based on their self-identification as Black or African American and who currently or in the past three years have held a role in a two-year institution as a Vice President, Deans, Associate Deans, and Directors in Student Affairs. A diverse group of participants for a phenomenological inquiry can range from three to four up to 15 participants (Chance, 2021); therefore, the plan was to seek six to eight participants.

The purpose of this qualitative study was to understand how Black women senior leaders in higher education manage stress. Therefore, to be eligible for this study, participants were women who self-identify as Black or African American. Additionally, the participants must currently or within the past three years be employed at a two-year higher education institution in a senior leadership position in Student Affairs. Lastly, these women must also have experienced stress while in these roles. A survey was created to determine the participants' eligibility.

Johnson and Christenson (2017) define purposive sampling as the researcher providing specific characteristics of the population of interest and locating individuals with those

characteristics. Participants for this research were selected through purposive sampling, also referred to as judgmental sampling. This method was employed to intentionally identify Black women serving in senior-level leadership positions within higher education in order to examine the stress they experience and to explore how institutions can implement strategies to reduce such stress. An additional reason to use a purposive sampling method is that in a qualitative phenomenological inquiry, the aim is not to simplify the findings to a population but to acquire insights and in-depth exploration of an overlooked phenomenon (Alhazmi & Kaufmann, 2022). With purposive sampling, the researcher specifies the characteristics of the population of interest and locates individuals with those characteristics (Johnson & Christenson, 2017). It was important for the researcher to find participants who are Black women senior-level leaders in Student Affairs roles who currently or in the past have experienced stress while in positions in higher education institutions. The researcher specified criteria potential participants were required to meet to be included in the research study, then obtained a random sample of this group of people (Johnson & Christenson, 2017).

Snowball Sampling

Snowball sampling was utilized to ensure there were ample participants in the research study. Snowball sampling involves asking research participants to identify one or more persons who meet the criteria and may be available and willing to participate in the study (Johnson & Christenson, 2017). In the beginning, only a few participants may be identified. However, over time as new participants provide suggestions for potential participants, the sample becomes larger and larger (Johnson & Christenson, 2017). The research setting was virtual interviews in the most comfortable setting for the participant. This setting may be in their homes or institution office spaces via Teams. The researcher also offered the participant the option to meet in a

neutral area where the research participant is comfortable. Since the research involved determining the amount of stress experienced by Black women in senior leadership positions, it was ideal to interview participants in their institution's office environment so the researcher had the opportunity to observe the stress they may experience in their environment.

Data Collection

After receiving signed consent forms from the participants, the data collection process can begin (Chance, 2021). The first instrument the researcher used in this research was a participant flyer (Appendix A). Additionally, a survey (Appendix B) was utilized to find participants who met the research criteria. The survey was created by the researcher to ensure the most useful information would be gathered and the appropriate participants were selected for the study. The survey was given digitally via Google Forms. The interview questions were shared with the participants ahead of the interview and included open-ended questions to avoid leading the participant (Chance, 2021). Initial questions for the survey included *Race, Gender, Current Job Title, Current Place of Employment, Have you experienced stress in your current senior level leadership position or a previous senior level leadership position, and Are you willing to participate in an interview regarding Managing Stress: Black Women in Senior Leadership Positions in Higher Education Institutions?* Once the researcher identified participants for the study, virtual interviews were conducted to learn more about the effects of stress on these women while in their positions. Appendix C was utilized to conduct the semi-structured interviews.

Semi-structured interviews were conducted to provide data based on the participants' perspectives and their words. Conducting a semi-structured interview allows the researcher to be flexible, interpret by participant, and structure questions in advance; however, interviews may follow the flow of the conversation in individual interviews rather than follow the guide exactly

(Patten & Newhart, 2018). The researcher encouraged participants to answer questions in their own way, without interruption, to collect as much information as possible. These interviews were videotaped utilizing Microsoft Teams and stored on the Governors State University (GSU) One Drive to ensure all information was being collected, saved, and stored. Additionally, this process allowed the interviewer to observe surroundings in the field and record observations (Johnson & Christenson, 2017).

Data Analysis

Qualitative data analysis requires the researcher to attempt to identify categories and general themes which appear repeatedly in the data (Johnson & Christenson, 2017). One method the researcher accomplished was through thematic analysis. Thematic analysis is a method utilized to analyze and describe qualitative data which involves interpretation in the processes of selecting codes and constructing themes, and requires searching across a data set to identify, analyze and report repeated patterns (Kiger & Varpioa, 2020). This procedure is also consistent with interpretative phenomenological analysis which is more focused on situated, explained, and lived experiences rather than on theoretical experiences (Johnson & Christenson, 2017). When seeking to understand a set of experiences, thoughts, or behaviors across a data set, thematic analysis is an appropriate and powerful method to use (Kiger & Varpioa, 2020). It was important for the researcher to have each participant recall a specific experience she had and describe the experience to the researcher (Johnson & Christenson, 2017). The qualitative report was written in narrative form and described findings through interviews and observations from an insider's perspective (Johnson & Christenson, 2017).

Using Clarke and Braun's thematic analysis, the researcher followed six steps. These steps were designed to be recursive rather than linear, which required the researcher to revisit

earlier steps as new data or emerging themes arose that warranted additional investigation (Kiger & Varpio, 2020). The six steps in Clarke and Braun's thematic analysis include familiarization with the data, generating initial codes, searching for themes, reviewing themes, defining and naming themes, and producing the report/manuscript (Kiger & Varpioa, 2020). Additionally, according to Kiger and Varpioa (2020), the researcher needs to avoid pitfalls including failure to thoroughly describe assumptions which undermine the analysis, lack of sufficient assessment, and a weak assessment in which the assumptions made in the report of findings are unconvincing or unfounded.

Validity/Reliability/Trustworthiness

According to Johnson and Christenson (2017), accurate interpretive validity requires the researcher to get inside the heads of the participants, by looking at the information through their eyes, seeing and feeling what they experience from their perspective, providing a valid account of their perspective. The researcher used participant feedback and shared their interpretation with the participants to gain clarity related for the interpretation of their statements (Johnson & Christenson, 2017). Johnson and Christenson (2017) asserts this technique identifies inaccuracies and provides the researcher with useful information.

Clarification of Research Role/Power

As a Black woman working in a mid-level leadership position in a higher education institution, this research is extremely important to the researcher. With plans to advance to a senior leadership position, the researcher sought to understand the causes of stress among Black women in senior leadership positions and ways the institution and Black women can reduce the extreme amounts of stress they experience. The researcher was determined to receive accurate

results in order to assist herself in the future along with other Black women in senior-level leadership positions.

Ethical Considerations

According to Johnson and Christenson (2017), a qualitative researcher's first ethical responsibility is to the participant. Pseudonyms are commonly used for qualitative research to protect and ensure the identity of the research participants are adequately concealed (Johnson & Christenson, 2017). When participants are uncomfortable with being too visible or too vulnerable, sometimes strategies such as fictionalizing and blurring times, places and identities may be negotiated into the use of their stories (Johnson and Christenson, 2017). According to Johnson and Christenson (2017), the American Educational Research Association (AERA) has identified five general principles researcher should always follow. These general principles include being professional and competent; integrity in being honest always, trustworthy, and never jeopardize the welfare of others; professional, scientific, and scholarly responsibility; respect for people's rights; dignity, and diversity to eliminate bias and discrimination; and a social responsibility, striving to act for the benefit of others in our society and world put this list in bullets (Johnson & Christenson, 2017).

Timeline

The recruitment period spanned four weeks starting in February 2025 and utilized outreach methods including social media, such as LinkedIn and Facebook, and networking with peers. According to Chance (2021), it can also be beneficial to conduct an online search, network with colleagues in various colleges and universities, professional organizations, social media, and affinity groups associated with higher education to recruit participants. Additionally, once participants were located, the researcher used snowball sampling to recruit additional

participants. A recruitment flyer was created to distribute through social media and colleagues. Colleagues were also asked to share the flyer on their social media platforms to increase the recruitment size.

Summary

Qualitative research provided a framework to determine how Black women in senior leadership positions in higher education manage stress. According to Johnson and Christenson (2017), qualitative research focuses on particular people and places to learn about their world and experiences from their perspective. By utilizing a phenomenological inquiry, the participants told stories of their lived experiences in senior leadership positions in higher education institutions and the researcher inquired about these experiences by asking follow-up open-ended questions to establish phenomenon. Within the chapter the methodology has been outlined for this research study. The research design, research participants, method of data collection, data analysis, validity, clarification of researcher role, and ethical consideration were all discussed to provide a view of the research study. These components framed the research study and assisted with understanding more about the stress experienced by Black women in senior leadership positions in higher education.

Chapter Four: Findings and Interpretations

Introduction

The purpose of this phenomenological study was to explore how Black women senior leaders in higher education manage stress. This research was guided by the central question: *How do Black women in senior-level Student Affairs roles including, Vice Presidents, Deans, Associate Deans, and Directors, manage the effects of stress in their current leadership roles in two-year higher education institutions?* To answer this question, the researcher conducted in-depth interviews with seven Black women currently serving in senior-level Student Affairs positions at two-year higher education institutions.

The aim of the research was to gain a deeper understanding of the stress management strategies employed by Black women leaders and to provide insights that may assist other Black women who aspire to similar leadership roles. The findings can help inform future leaders to navigate the unique stressors they may face on their professional journey in higher education. Through data analysis, four major themes emerged: (1) the double bind of racism and sexism; (2) the physical and mental symptoms of stress; (3) the use of self-care activities; and (4) strategic support seeking behaviors performed by the participants. In addition to these core themes, this study also highlighted participants' leadership styles, the institutional support currently available to them, and the additional resources they believe are needed to effectively manage the demands of their roles. The following sections present each of these themes in detail, supported by rich excerpts from participant narratives.

Furthermore, this chapter presents the interpretation and analysis of semi-structured interviews conducted with Black women senior leaders who work at two-year institutions in the Midwest, South, and Northeast regions of the United States. An exploratory qualitative approach

was employed to examine participants' attitudes and gain a deeper understanding of the phenomenon of stress in leadership, its contributing circumstances, lived impact, and shape of the broader social and institutional context.

This approach enabled the researcher to follow a bottom-up, inductive process, in which patterns and concepts are derived from the data itself rather than imposed in advance, moving from raw data to patterns and ultimately to conceptual understanding (Johnson & Christenson, 2017).The interviews were conducted virtually using Microsoft Teams platform, and each session was audio recorded and transcribed for analysis. A codebook was developed and used to systematically categorize and analyze the data, allowing for the identification of recurring themes and significant patterns across participant narratives.

Participants

This section provides a brief overview of the participant recruitment process and the demographic characteristics of the study participants, which were collected through a screening tool and during the interviews. Demographic information includes participants' age, current position within their two-year institution, number of years in their current role, total years of experience in higher education, highest degree earned, and the geographic region in which their institution is located.

Black women senior leaders were recruited through several methods, including outreach via publicly available email addresses, posts of the participant flyer on social media sites such as Facebook and LinkedIn, and snowball sampling. After responding to the researcher's initial outreach, each potential participant received an email thanking her for her interest and inviting her to complete an initial screening survey to determine eligibility. Participants were eligible if they: 1) self-identified as a Black Woman, 2) worked currently or within the past three years held

a senior leadership position as a Vice President, Dean, Associate Dean, or Director in a Student Affairs role, and 3) were employed at a two-year higher education institution.

Those who met the eligibility criteria were then asked to complete an informed consent form. Once the signed consent form was received, participants were sent a copy of the research questions and a link to schedule their interview, which was conducted via Microsoft Teams.

Table 1

Participant Overview

Pseudonym	Age	Current Role	Years in Current Role	Years in Higher Ed	Years in Leadership	Highest Degree Earned	Region
Carmen Blake	39	Executive Director, Education & Strategic Initiatives	2	14	6	MA	Midwest
Dr. Danielle Harper	48	Director of Admission and Records	7	21	20	Ed.D	South
Melanie Rhodes	55	Director of Advising and Counseling	9	23	3	MA	South
Dr. Ayana Wells	41	Associate Dean of Academic Affairs	1	15	11	Ed.D	Northeast
Nicole Jefferson	55	Associate Dean of Instruction	1	31	10	MPA	Midwest
Tamika Ellis	46	Director of Student Development Projects/Grant Management	3	3	12	MBA	Midwest
Brianna Tate	51	Director of Testing Services	19	19	12	MEd	South

Pseudonyms were used to protect the identities of the participants. A brief profile of each of the Black women senior leaders who contributed to the study is presented below.

Carmen Blake is a 39-year-old Executive Director of Education and Strategic Initiatives at a two-year institution in the Midwest region of the United States. She has served in this role for two years and has worked in higher ecation for a total of 14 years, including six years in senior leadership. Carmen holds a master's degree and is currently in the dissertation phase of her doctoral program, identifying as "ABD."

Dr. Danielle Harper is a 48-year-old Director of Admission and Records at a two-year institution in the South region. She has been in this position for seven years and has worked in higher education for 21 years, with 20 of those years in leadership roles. Dr. Harper holds a Doctorate in Education and has also served in interim Associate Dean roles at both her current and previous institutions.

Melanie Rhodes is a 55-year-old Director of Advising and Counseling at a two-year institution in the South. She has been in her current role for nine years and has worked in higher education for 23 years, beginning her career in a lab at a 4-year institution. Although her current title has changed to reflect a leadership position, she has formally been in a senior leadership role for the past three years. Melanie holds a master's degree and is currently pursuing a Ph.D.

Dr. Ayana Wells is a 41-year-old Associate Dean of Academic Affairs at a two-year institution in the Northeast region. She has held this role for one year and has been in leadership for 11 years. Prior to her current role, she served for seven years as an Associate Dean of Academic Advising at a two-year institution in the Midwest. Dr. Wells holds a Doctorate in Education (Ed.D.) and balances her leadership responsibilities with parenting two young children under the age of six.

Nicole Jefferson is a 55-year-old Associate Dean of Instruction at a two-year institution in the Midwest region. She has been in her current role for one year and has served in senior

leadership positions for 10 years, including work in strategic initiatives, cross functional team leadership, and institutional planning. Nicole has worked in higher education for 31 years, most of which has been spent at the same institution. She holds a Master of Public Administration (MPA) and is a doctoral candidate, expecting to complete her degree in August 2025.

Tamika Ellis is a 46-year-old Director of Student Development Projects and Grant Management at a 2-year institution in the Midwest region. She has held this position for three years and is the most recent entrant in higher education among the participants, with three years of experience. Despite her new entry into higher education leadership, she has 12 years of experience in leadership across other sectors. Tamika holds a Master of Business Administration (MBA).

Brianna Tate is a 51-year-old Director of Testing Services at a two-year institution in the South. She has worked in higher education for 19 years, all of which she has spent in her current position. Over time, she has taken on additional responsibilities across multiple campuses, resulting in a reclassification of her role into a leadership position. Brianna has been in leadership for 12 years and holds a Master of Education (M.Ed.).

Table 1 provides an overview of the participants' demographics and professional characteristics, including age, current job title, years in their current role, total years of experience in higher education and leadership, highest degree earned, and the geographic region of their institution.

A total of eight women completed the prescreening tool, and five women responded to direct email invitations to participate in the study. However, only seven participants met the eligibility criteria and completed the interview process. All interviews were conducted in May and June of 2025.

Identification of Themes

Thematic analysis was the method utilized to analyze and describe the qualitative data collected in this study. This approach involved interpretive processes in which codes were selected, and themes were constructed by systematically searching across the dataset to identify, analyze, and report recurring patterns (Kiger & Varpioa, 2020). A codebook was developed and utilized to organize the data and facilitate the clear identification of the emerging themes relevant to the participants' lived experiences.

The analysis revealed four central themes that reflect how Black women in senior leadership positions in two-year institutions experience and manage stress: (1) Double Bind, (2) Symptoms of Stress, (3) Self-care activities, and (4) Strategic Support Seeking. The following sections explore each theme in depth, illustrating how participants navigated their leadership roles amid systemic pressures and personal wellness needs.

Theme 1: Double Bind

Black women in higher education often face compounded marginalization due to the intersection of race and gender. While White women may encounter gender bias and Black men may experience racial discrimination, Black women navigate both simultaneously, what has been described in the literature as the double bind (Marion, 2023). This dual marginalization means they are not afforded the privileges or visibility that accompanies being part of a dominant racial or gender group, placing them in a uniquely disadvantaged position within leadership structures.

Many participants in this study shared experiences that reflected the stress caused by racial and gender disparities in their leadership roles. The double bind of racism and sexism manifested in how they were perceived and treated by colleagues, particularly other senior leaders who did not share their racial or gender identity.

For example, Brianna described an experience while serving on a hiring committee, where she felt compelled to advocate for a qualified Black woman candidate for a Dean's position. Despite the candidate's strong resume and relevant experience, Brianna sensed bias from the committee members based on the candidate's race and gender. She stated:

> I was the only African American on the committee and I just really felt like I had to be brave and speak up for this person. Because we're comparing her resume and her credentials against others. And obviously she had a ton of experience, and I could not find a reason not to bring her in.

Similarly, Nicole Jefferson identified racial undertones as a primary source of stress in her leadership experience. She described feeling mentally exhausted from having to consistently "over prepare, over perform, and over explain" in order to be taken seriously. She further reflected on the psychological toll of constantly being aware of how her actions were perceived:

> There was also the pressure to represent, being one of the few Black women in leadership meant that I was constantly aware of how my actions might be viewed.

Nicole acknowledged that being one of the few Black women on campus created "layers of stress and self-monitoring," stemming not only from external expectations but also internalized pressures to meet an unspoken, elevated standard. For many participants, the intersection of race and gender resulted in a constant negotiation of identity and expectations, adding an extra layer of emotional and cognitive labor to their leadership roles.

Racism

Gause (2022) posits that racial microaggressions are common experiences for Black women and are not confined to professional spaces; in fact, they often permeate all aspects of life. Participants in this study affirmed this reality, describing how racial bias and

microaggressions added significant stress to their leadership roles. Melainie, for example, shared that the racialized experiences she encountered extended beyond the workplace and were part of her everyday life. She stated:

> I've been Black all my life, so it's not only am I Black in my professional life I'm Black always right. So, I deal with it.

Although she acknowledged the inevitably of encountering racial bias, Melanie emphasized the added stress it created in her leadership role. She described the microaggressions she encountered daily, explaining how they influenced her decision making and required constant vigilance in her position.

Dr. Ayana Wells shared a similar sentiment, particularly in the context of working under a Black college president. She described the heightened expectations placed on Black staff to represent the president well and ensure his success:

> Some of the challenges were [that] the expectations weren't the same, right? Because we had a Black leader, the expectation of the Black senior staff were not the same as our other colleagues. The expectation was more.

This racial dynamic created added pressure on Dr. Wells and her peers to be hyper prepared, not just for their own responsibilities but also to protect the professional image of their leader. She also noted the disparities in how her decisions were received depending on the racial identity of the staff involved:

> So, it always felt like I would be defending some decisions I made or defending the decisions of my staff members who were women or men of color. When I had staff members that were of color who were constantly what felt like in, I don't know, defense mode, we were always having to explain why we were doing X, Y

> and Z. In other spaces, or in previous times, if I had a staff member who was not of color in the same position, none of those questions ever came up, ever.

Dr. Wells was able to clearly identify the racial inconsistencies in how decisions were scrutinized, especially when it involved Black staff members. These inequities added unnecessary stress and pressure to her role as a leader.

Dr. Danielle Harper also shared a significant racialized experience that occurred while working in the Southern region of the United States. She reflected:

> If I was in [the Midwest], I might have a different answer, because when I was in [the Midwest], I didn't experience problems being in leadership positions. But in [the South], I have really encountered a lot of [racial] bias.

She recounted an incident in which a White female team member made false accusations against her. Rather than being given an opportunity to explain, Dr. Harper was reprimanded without question. She had to fight for over a year to clear her name, eventually being vindicated by human resources, who removed the disciplinary action from her record and compensated her for a year's worth of work. The emotional toll of navigating this unjust experience added to the ongoing racial stress she endured in her leadership role.

Sexism

Anderson (2023) argues that the underrepresentation of women in senior higher education leadership is often attributed to pervasive gender bias and stereotyping. Participants in this study echoed this reality. For example, Carmen recounted multiple instances of gender discrimination by her college president; he frequently interrupted her, attempted to dictate her feelings or reframe her perspective, and dismissed her emotions in favor of his own. Carmen summarized

his behavior with the phrase “he tried to little Black girl me”. When asked to elaborate, she explained:

> It's the youth, the age. You know you’re a Black woman. You know you're young and people just don't think you know what you're doing. And so, for him, it was the same thing. Like you don't know what experiences you need, or you don't know what's best for you. So, I'm going to tell you what you're going to do. And that's what you're going to do.

By comparing her to his much younger daughter and insisting that only he knew what was best for her, he dismissed Carmen’s professional judgment and treated her as if she lacked the ability to make her own decisions.

Melanie also reflected on the effects of the double bind of racism and sexism when her institution briefly appointed a Black woman president. Although the Black woman president recognized and spoke out about the microaggressions and implicit bias she encountered in her leadership role, these challenges ultimately contributed to her tenure being short lived. Melanie noted that the incoming president’s “I belong” slogan rang hollow, since Black women remained the last to be considered for senior roles. When asked how the institution could do better, Melanie urged:

> They could truly diversify, starting at the top. Then you need to really have some true open dialogue.

She believes that genuine diversification of leadership would not only create more opportunities for Black women but also signal to all students that inclusivity is more than a slogan, it is a lived practice.

Theme 2: Symptoms of Stress

After identifying the primary sources of stress experienced by Black women in two-year higher education institutions, it became equally important to explore how these women recognized and described the symptoms of their stress. This discovery is particularly significant given the increased risk of hypertension, a key contributor to cardiovascular disease, which remains the leading cause of death among women in the United States (Gaston et al., 2023). The participants' accounts revealed two distinct subthemes: (1) physical symptoms and (2) mental symptoms of stress.

For example, during COVID-19, Dr. Ayana Wells reported experiencing both physical and mental symptoms. She described suffering from having persistent headaches, feeling overstimulated, and struggling to relax. Similarly, Nicole Jefferson also recognized signs of stress during the pandemic, particularly while overseeing the transition of the college's academic support services to a fully online format. She experienced tension, frequent headaches, and insomnia, all of which she attributed to the pressure and demands of the role during a time of crisis.

Physical Symptoms

Physical symptoms of stress often manifest in the body as aches, tension, or other physiological responses. For the participants in this study, these physical manifestations served as a key indicator of the ongoing stress they were navigating in their leadership roles. Carmen described feeling persistent tension in her shoulders as a result of workplace stress. She noted that this physical discomfort also affected her ability to maintain the emotional discipline often expected of leaders, stating:

> My shoulders are tense and stuff like that. And my work, my filter is gone. And so, you know, we say code switching a lot. So oftentimes you [must] do that.

Dr. Harper recognized her stress through the reappearance of eczema, which would flare up during high-pressure times, such as planning for commencement. Though she made a conscious effort to remain composed for the sake of her team, her body often signaled the stress she attempted to conceal:

> I have eczema and during that time my eczema will flare up and I know, OK. I'm stressed because it's, you know, flaring where I will have to use the ointment to get it to calm down. And so that's usually how my family as well as myself can tell. OK, you're stressing.

For Brianna, stress was physically noticeable when her heart began to beat faster, a bodily reaction she had learned to associate with overwhelming situations.

Tamika shared that stress not only required her to take blood pressure medication, but also triggered increased eating, both of which are significant in the context of Black women's health. According to Gaston et al. (2023), hypertension is a leading cause of cardiovascular disease among Black women, and a suboptimal diet is a major contributing factor.

These experiences highlight how physical stress responses serve as critical warning signs. For Black women in leadership, acknowledging and understanding these symptoms is essential to protecting their overall health and wellness while navigating the pressures of their roles.

Mental Symptoms

In addition to physical manifestations, mental health symptoms were also prevalent among participants in this study. These symptoms ranged from emotional exhaustion to chronic

worry and often reflected the internalized pressure of leadership compounded by race and gender-related stressors.

Melanie described experiencing persistent fear and anxiety while tasked with overhauling the institution's advising services for the approximately 25,000 students. She recalled how the scope of the responsibility weighed on her, particularly because she knew the transformation could not be achieved alone. Her fear stemmed from the challenge of generating buy-in from her team while navigating the enormity of the task.

Nicole reflected on her mental and emotional state during the COVID-19 pandemic as she led efforts to move all academic support services online. The stress she encountered taught her valuable lessons about self-care and shared leadership. She stated:

> [There was a] lack of emotional support because you know, this is a thing that everybody was dealing with at this time, feeling overwhelmed, mentally fatigued. [We were] constantly making decisions, because everybody was trying to figure that whole piece out.

The mental toll of the constant decisions, fatigue, and insufficient support underscored the isolating burden Nicole experienced as a leader during a crisis.

Similarly, Dr. Ayana Wells described the mental exhaustion she faced during the pandemic. In her case, the stress was intensified by blurred boundaries between work and personal life, especially as she navigated parenting small children while managing a leadership role. She recalled:

> Not being able to sleep well because I'm constantly thinking about what else I [need] to do. On top of having babies at home, so it was, I think those things that made me realize like, OK, I'm feeling burnt out. It can be overwhelming at times.

Dr. Wells highlighted how the never-ending stream of emails, texts, and work-related requests outside of normal hours left her little time to decompress, which ultimately led to emotional burnout. According to Bauwens (2019), burnout is both a psychological and physiological response to prolonged workplace stress and is often marked by emotional exhaustion and detachment from work. For Black women leaders, especially those balancing caregiving responsibilities, this risk is even more acute.

These findings underscore the need for higher education institutions to take intentional steps to address mental health and prevent burnout among Black women in leadership. Failing to do so not only places individuals at risk but also threatens institutional stability by increasing turnover, lowering performance, and stifling innovation (Bauwens, 2019).

Theme 3: Self-Care Activities

After recognizing the physical and mental symptoms of stress, participants described the importance of identifying effective strategies to manage or reduce stress to prevent further extended harm. According to Adkins-Jackson et al. (2023), self-care is defined as the evolution and support of both the consciousness and a lifestyle that restores balance. Three sub-themes emerged from participants' self-care practices: (1) spirituality, (2) boundary setting, and (3) wellness.

Spirituality

Spirituality was a dominant form of self-care described by participants, encompassing practices such as prayer, meditation, and devotional reading. This spiritual foundation was often described as a primary source of strength, peace, and clarity during stressful times.

Nicole emphasized the centrality of her faith in navigating stress, speaking with deep conviction about how her spiritual practices sustain her both personally and professionally:

> I will have to honestly say that my faith is my foundation. Daily prayers, devotional reading, and just moments of spiritual reflection have helped me to center and remind me that I'm not navigating these challenges alone. Turning to God for guidance brings peace and clarity, especially during high pressure or emotionally taxing moments. I think that the spiritual grounding is not just a coping mechanism, but it's also a source of strength.

Similarly, Brianna described how a moment of silent prayer in her office before a stressful meeting or presentation helped her maintain composure:

> A moment of reflection and speaking to God helps to deal with stress.

Melanie shared that her spirituality informs every aspect of her life, from how she begins her day to how she interacts with others under pressure. She described her faith as essential:

> Without my spirituality, I can't do it. Period. [Prayer] ties into everything I do. When I wake up, when I get up and I go to work, how I view people, how I see things, how I keep from having resentment from getting angry. And so, my spirituality is number one.

Likewise, Dr. Harper described combining prayer and walking as a means of reducing stress and gaining mental clarity:

> I try to find ways to release [stress]. And so, I find that going on walks helps me when I go on walks, I pray. Having faith in God is what really has me, I think, able to handle all the things that I endure. It helps me focus and get clarity on what I need to do.

These narratives reveal that spirituality for these women was more than just a routine, it was a deeply ingrained part of how they survive and lead. It provided a spiritual lens through

which they interpreted stress, found comfort, and centered themselves amid institutional demands. While spirituality did not replace other coping strategies, it served as an indispensable, internal resource that many participants relied on consistently.

Boundary Setting

Many of the participants expressed difficulty separating their personal and professional obligations. This lack of separation often led to feelings of overload and the neglect of their families. As a result, several participants became intentional about establishing workplace boundaries to better manage their stress and preserve their well-being.

Dr. Wells discussed how she drew boundaries at work, especially during the heightened stress of the COVID-19 pandemic. She began taking walks during her lunch breaks to create space for herself and made it a point to use her paid time off benefits, something she also encourages her staff to implement:

> I know a lot of staff struggle with that and people often feel guilty for using their time, but I'm an advocate for using time because you need it to reset and to balance yourself.

She also learned through mentorship that her non-Black colleagues were more likely to decline additional responsibilities when they felt overwhelmed; while she and other Black women in senior leadership often defaulted to saying yes. She reflected:

> Anytime myself or other Black women who were in senior leadership, if we were asked to do something, without question, it was a yes. My colleagues? Oh, it was a no. ‘I don't have the bandwidth.’ ‘I can't take on anything else.’ And I was like, oh. It's a yes. Every time you ask me and it's a no, every time they are asked.

Initially, she believed saying yes would demonstrate loyalty and prove her value as a leader. However, she later recognized that this constant compliance contributed to burnout. This internalized pressure aligns with the Strong Black Woman (SBW) archetype, which promotes overwork, self-sacrifice, and a resistance to asking for help (Geyton et al., 2023). Dr. Wells explained:

> No, just never felt like an option. Like how dare I say no, I'm not going to do this when I've been granted the opportunity to be in this position and to be in leadership. Why would I tell somebody no?

She also noted the pressure to be visibly engaged on campus, attending games and student events, while her colleagues often opted out of these events:

> My colleagues weren't there. I didn't see them showing up to those events. So, I think it was just the added stress of needing to be seen needing to be heard, needing to be present so that your value is solidified. Meanwhile, at 4:59 they're headed [home].

As a result of this realization, she implemented a personal boundary by limiting her email communications after work hours:

> When I come home, I oftentimes will check e-mail just as one final glance over around 6:00 PM, and then I close it, because I still want to make time for myself and for my own family.

Dr. Harper also recognized the need to set firmer boundaries and sought counseling to help her implement them, both professionally and personally. Prior to therapy, she found that people would often violate her boundaries without consequence. Therapy gave her the tools to set limits and hold others accountable, even when they resisted. She shared:

> It really, had my leadership team looking like we can no longer use her for everything we need done. Just because she won't say, 'I can't do that at this time.' So, I think that really changed the amount of pressure that I allowed myself to take on when I started to do that. And it was respectfully, but I had to let them know that. Yeah, I can't continue in that way.

Nicole also emphasized the value of protecting time for herself and her family. She made clear boundaries between work and personal time, including "logging off at reasonable hour and making time for rest and family activities."

Collectively, these narratives reflect how Black women leaders in higher education must unlearn harmful expectations tied to the SBW schema and instead adopt boundary-setting as a critical form of self-preservation and resistance to institutional overload.

Wellness

Wellness was an important factor for senior leaders in this study who sought to manage their stress effectively. Participants described engaging in wellness practices such as attending counseling sessions and engaging in physical activities like exercise and walking. According to McCall et al. (2025), a stigma around counseling persists within many Black families. Despite their resistance, several participants overcame those cultural barriers in order to prioritize their mental health.

For example, although therapy was not widely accepted in her family culture, Dr. Harper chose to attend counseling to help her cope with the racism she was experiencing from a staff member. Her family even cautioned her not to disclose too much of her personal information to the counselor. Nevertheless, Dr. Harper found therapy to be a critical outlet:

> I feel like that really was a successful door that was open in helping me to release without judgment the way that I was feeling about what I was going through, and the counselors really did a great job at helping me to discover ways that I could manage it. It was so impactful that I signed my children up to attend counseling sessions as well because of our family situations.

Many of the participants emphasized the value of having a therapist when offering advice for Black women aspiring to senior leadership in higher education. Carmen's advice was direct:

> "stay grounded in the work and get a therapist."

She feels it is important to talk to someone outside of the institution who is able to offer a helpful external perspective on how to manage work-related stress.

Although Black women often face barriers to counseling, such as cost, limited time, lack of awareness about services, fear of being prescribed medication, and the lack of culturally competent therapist (McCall et al., 2025), participants in this study found ways to manage these challenges. Dr. Wells noted that virtual therapy, made more accessible after the COVID-19 pandemic, helped her and her staff prioritize mental health.

> So many people are taking advantage of it now because you could do that on your lunch break. Take your session. To have that balance. Those are the things that really help just kind of maintain some peace, some inner peace just in the midst of chaos.

Some institutions have also taken steps to support employee wellness. Melanie shared that her college offers five free sessions with a licensed counselor through its Employee Assistance Program (EAP). Although she has not personally used the service, she valued its availability. Similarly, Dr. Wells mentioned that counseling services on her campus have been

extended to employees as well, though she voiced concerns about staff receiving counseling from institutional colleagues rather than external providers.

Beyond therapy, participants also engaged in other wellness activities. Melanie discussed her institution's wellness program, which permits staff to use the fitness center during work hours with supervisor approval, a benefit she frequently uses:

> We do have a wellness program and I'm very into making sure that I go exercise. You know that type of fitness to relieve my stress. The wellness program is really great.

Nicole incorporated mindfulness, reflection, and journaling into her routine to help her recenter and stay grounded during periods of high stress. She reported that these practices were effective in calming her mind and reducing anxiety.

Brianna observed that mindfulness techniques seemed more openly embraced by her colleagues who did not share her racial identity. While she acknowledged that mindfulness is not race-specific, she speculated that these practices were more profession-oriented among her peers, particularly when they recommend techniques to others:

> [My colleague] has techniques that she shares with her students and other colleagues about how to manage that stress.

Brianna also used physical activity as a wellness strategy. Although she admitted to struggling with consistency, she shared:

> I also try to exercise. I haven't been doing the best job with that, but I do try to exercise if I'm feeling stressed. Like once I get home I [may] go to the gym or go for a walk. That even makes me feel better. But I feel like that's something that some of them will do also.

Wellness practices, including therapy, fitness, mindfulness, and institutional supports, served as critical tools for stress management among these Black women leaders. Despite cultural stigmas and systemic challenges, these leaders found ways to prioritize their wellness and model it for others.

Theme 4: Strategic Support Seeking

The fourth theme that emerged from the data centers around the intentional pursuit of support and mentorship, particularly for other Black women in leadership roles. Having a strong support system, both within the institution and externally through professional networks or communities, was seen as essential for managing stress in leadership (Sharma et al., 2024). Two subthemes emerged under this theme: (1) mentors and (2) organizations.

Mentors

When asked about advice she would give to Black women aspiring to senior leadership, Melanie emphasized the value of building a trustworthy support system, specifically finding someone to share with openly, without fear of judgment, who understands the unique stressors of the work environment:

> Who is that person that can kind of not only listen, but kind of calm you down, give you another perspective? That's why I said if you can find that one, that one that you could trust in your sector of career, and hone in on them and develop that relationship. That would be an excellent person to have. Because that person can totally relate to what you're talking about.

Melanie also noted that the relationship could be reciprocal; both parties could serve as a sounding board for one another. However, she strongly believed that having a Black woman

mentor was especially important to ensure shared understanding and cultural resonance. This connection allowed for open conversation that felt safe and validating.

Brianna shared that she has been fortunate to build relationships with several Black women colleagues on campus, creating a supportive network where she can openly express frustrations and reflect on shared experiences. While many White women also feel comfortable approaching her to vent, Brianna expressed that she is most at ease confiding in other Black women who have encountered similar challenges. As she explained:

> I feel more comfortable being myself and truly honest about what I'm feeling if it's with someone that has experienced something in the same way that I have.

This feeling underscores the critical role of identity-based support systems in helping Black women leaders navigate racialized stress within predominately White institutions.

Carmen similarly highlighted the importance of having someone within the institution who can offer support and a space to vent when the stresses of leadership becomes overwhelming:

> Find at least one person on campus that you can lean on or who at least looks out for you.

Although Tamika is still in the process of developing consistent coping mechanisms to manage her work-related stress, she emphasized the importance of workplace connections in providing emotional support.

> I do have two people that I can confide in, that is in the workplace. We are aligned together, we talk things through.

These relationships offer a space for reflection and solidarity, reinforcing the value of trusted peer support in navigating leadership-related challenges.

Dr. Wells described her own experience with mentorship, which developed organically while she was pursuing her doctoral degree. She acknowledged that this relationship might not have emerged otherwise and suggested that institutions should intentionally implement mentorship as part of the onboarding process for new senior leaders:

> Mentorship would be ideal because you could very well be very new to a role, and there's an expectation that you know what you're doing, and you know how to do it, and you know how to lead people in different scenarios, [but] it's new to you too. So, at what point did you learn it?

She believed that structured mentorship could bridge the knowledge and support gap that often exists when entering a new institution or senior-level role. By having mentors available, new leaders are not left to navigate stressful or unfamiliar situations alone. Institutionalizing such mentorship programs could lead to stronger retention, leadership development, and stress reduction for Black women leaders.

Organizations

Participation in professional and community-based organizations also emerged as a key strategy for mentorship, support and advancement among Black women senior leaders. These organizations provided more than just networking opportunities; they served as sources of encouragement, emotional support, and shared identity.

Melanie emphasized the importance of her involvement in organizations that intentionally support Black communities, including her sorority and The Links Incorporated, a national organization of approximately 17,000 accomplished Black women. She described the motivation she receives from being surrounded by high-achieving Black women:

> You have all of these people, political figures, everybody, and then you go, and you see them all the time. I mean, movers and shakers, and that is one great motivator when you surround yourself with women and you look at them, you're like, oh my gosh, she's a multi-millionaire. 'I'm now the President of this.' 'I'm now the VP of that.' So that's motivating. You see this Black girl magic all the time. And you're like, oh, there's nothing I can't do. And then on top of that, we all motivate each other.

Melanie also emphasized the value of emotional and life lesson support that extends beyond professional success. She recalled how the group rallied around a member who experienced the devastating loss of her daughter. The ability to rely on each other in both triumph and tragedy, she said, is what made the group invaluable:

> That's a support system that you can't break. And so, when you do that and you be intentional, Black women, you go find those Black girl magic organizations, and you try to get in it.

Dr. Harper discussed the significance of an on-campus organization formed specifically by and for Black women at her institution. The group was self-funded through dues, often deducted directly from members' paychecks. Together, they read and discussed books focused on navigating institutional bias and gender discrimination. Dr. Harper described how the group offered affirmation and clarity in difficult times:

> I think that is a really big support because sometimes you really feel isolated, like, these things are happening to only you. But when you guys can come together as a group, then you see. 'OK. This is not happening to just me.' Others are having

> to endure this. And in that you are finding, I would say, like refuge or comfort. Because they can share what they did to manage.

The organization not only provided practical support, but also helped participants embrace and take pride in their identity as Black women in leadership. By offering solidarity around personal expression, such as hair styles and attire, the group contributed to institutional culture change by encouraging members to show up authentically.

Nicole also affirmed the importance of seeking community and mentorship in predominantly White or male-dominated spaces. When asked what advice she would give to aspiring Black women senior leaders, she offered this:

> Surround yourself with mentors, sister friends, and thought partners who understand the unique weight you may carry in a predominantly White or male-dominated spaces. These relationships are not just support systems; they are lifelines for resilience.

Through collective connection, both formal and informal, these Black women in leadership found strength, affirmation, and practical strategies to navigate their careers while protecting their mental and emotional well-being.

Summary

This study explored the central research question: *How do Black women in senior-level Student Affairs roles, including Vice Presidents, Provosts, Deans, and Directors, manage the effects of stress in their current leadership roles in two-year higher education institutions?* Through rich, lived narratives, participants offered invaluable insights into navigating high-stakes leadership environments while preserving their well-being and resilience. Four major themes emerged from the data: (1) double bind, encompassing both racism and sexism; (2)

symptoms of stress, including both physical and mental manifestations; (3) self-care activities, such as spirituality practices, mindfulness, and exercise; and (4) strategic support seeking, including mentorship from other Black women and engagement in professional and community networks.

Despite facing persistent bias, institutional barriers, and systemic inequities, participants demonstrated intentionality recognizing, responding to, and mitigating stress. Their experiences not only reflect the complexities of intersectionality in leadership, but also highlight the structural shortcomings of higher education institutions in supporting minoritized leaders.

These findings directly address the purpose of the study and inform a deeper understanding of the unique challenges and coping strategies of Black women leaders in community colleges. They also provide a critical foundation for the implications, policy recommendations, and directions for future research presented in Chapter 5, where the broader relevance of these experiences for higher education leadership development will be further explored.

Chapter 5: Discussion

Introduction

This chapter presents the interpretation of findings from a phenomenological study that explored how Black women in senior-level Student Affairs roles manage stress within two-year higher education institutions. A phenomenological approach was used to explore the lived experiences of stress these women encountered while in their leadership roles and to understand how they make meaning of those experiences (Barkhuizen et al., 2022; Chance, 2021).

The study was grounded in the need to better understand the intersecting impacts of racism, sexism, and institutional expectations on Black women leaders' perspectives that are often overlooked in existing research. Through the narratives of seven participants, the study illuminated both the sources of stress and intentional strategies these women used to maintain resilience, effectiveness, and personal well-being.

To address this gap, the central research question guiding this study was: *How do Black women in senior-level Student Affairs roles, including Vice Presidents, Provosts, Deans, and Directors, manage the effects of stress in their current leadership roles at two-year higher education institutions?*

This chapter offers a brief summary of the study, discusses the findings in connection to existing literature and theory, and outlines the implications for policy practice, and future research.

Overview of Study

Black Feminist Thought (BFT) and the Strong Black Woman Collective (SBWC) served as the guiding theoretical frameworks for this research study. These frameworks not only informed the conceptual design of the study but also shaped the interpretation of the participants'

narratives and the emergence of key themes during analysis. BFT centers the experiences of Black women by acknowledging the interconnectedness of race, gender and class oppression, and recognizing Black women as knowledge cultivators who resist dominant narratives through their lived experiences (Collins, 2000). This lens allowed for a nuanced interpretation of the participants' stories, especially in identifying how they navigated stress within institutional environments shaped by systemic inequality.

The SBWC framework, developed by Davis and Afif (2019) builds on the historically constructed image of Strong Black Woman (SBW), an image that has often functioned as a controlling stereotype used to uphold Black women's perceived inferiority. While the traditional SBW schema has contributed to harmful expectations of invulnerability, self-sacrifice, and emotional suppression, the SBWC reframes this image through a collectivist lens that values vulnerability, authenticity, and shared emotional labor among Black women. This framework was essential in interpreting the participants' intentional efforts to seek support, prioritize wellness, and form connections with other Black women leaders as acts of resistance and resilience rather than weakness. It helped illuminate how strength was redefined by the participants, not as silent endurance, but as active engagement in community, mentorship, and self-reservation.

Together, BFT and SBWC provided an interpretive foundation to understand the deeper social and cultural meanings embedded in the participants' stress management strategies and leadership practices within two-year higher education institutions.

Discussion of Findings

The purpose of this study was to explore how Black women in senior-level leadership roles in Student Affairs at two-year institutions manage stress. Using a phenomenological

approach, seven Black women were interviewed to uncover the meaning they attribute to their lived experiences and to better understand the stressors they encounter in leadership. Participants provided in-depth accounts of the challenges they face, the ways they recognize stress, the strategies they use to manage it, and the types of institutional supports they believe are necessary to sustain Black women in leadership roles.

This study fills a critical gap in the literature by centering the experiences of Black women, who are often underrepresented in research and decision-making spaces in higher education. By focusing on two-year institutions, which are frequently overlooked in leadership studies, this research highlights the unique pressures faced by senior leaders in these environments, especially those who navigate the intersecting oppressions of race and gender.

Participants were employed at institutions across the Midwest, Northeast, and South. Semi-structured interviews conducted via Microsoft Teams allowed participants the freedom to share openly and control the depth of their responses. Interviews were recorded, transcribed, and analyzed using thematic analysis, following Kiger and Varpio's (2020) framework. Coding and theme development were guided by a researcher-developed codebook, enabling consistent interpretation of patterns across narratives.

The findings yielded four key themes, each of which reveals not only Black women leaders experience, but also why their experiences demand attention and systemic change.

Theme 1: Racial and Gender Bias (The Double Bind)

The double bind of racism and sexism was a recurring thread across the narratives of Black women in this study. Participants consistently described experiences in which race, gender, or the intersection of both created unique challenges to credibility, advancement, and recognition in their leadership roles. Anderson (2023) asserts that this intersectional burden

compounds the difficulty of attaining and sustaining leadership positions in higher education for Black women.

Dr. Harper shared a striking example of racial bias. Although she had successfully served as interim Dean, she was ultimately overlooked for the permanent role, despite her qualifications, due to reasons that, in her view, were unrelated to merit. Her story reflects what Turner et al. (2011) identify as a pattern Black women often face, heightened scrutiny and pressure to prove themselves, while receiving fewer opportunities to advance.

Carmen's experience illustrated gendered bias in the form of condescension from a Black male President, whom she felt dismissed her professional insight. She recalled how he would explain her own ideas back to her or attempt to dictate her thoughts and decisions, describing this interaction as his effort to "little Black girl" her. Carmen's account highlights how gendered oppression can emerge even with racially shared spaces, a dynamic emphasized by Davis (2018) and echoed by BFT, which asserts that the intersection of race and gender fundamentally shapes Black women's lived realities (Collins, 1989; Gause, 2022).

Dr. Wells reinforced the layered expectations placed on Black leaders when working under a Black president. She felt that Black staff were held to higher standards, not only to support institutional goals but also to ensure that the president, and by extension themselves, were respected. Her insight underscores the internalized and externalized expectations placed on Black professionals to "represent well," often at the cost of their own psychological safety.

Nicole's narrative brought this theme full circle. She described how, despite being present at decision-making tables, her voice was routinely undervalued. This sense of being visible yet unheard reflects what Gause (2022) describes as the layered intersectionality Black

women must navigate, where race, gender, and institutional politics intersect in ways that render them simultaneously included and invisible.

These stories illustrate how the double bind of racial and gender bias is not abstract; it is embedded in daily interactions, hiring decisions, and leadership dynamics. Beyond individual frustration, these experiences reveal structural inequities that erode morale and obstruct institutional equity. Understanding this theme is essential not only for validating the experiences of Black women in leadership but also for forming institutional policies that address bias at its root.

Theme 2: Recognizing Symptoms of Stress

The SBWC framework emphasizes how Black women cultivate strength through shared communication and collective identity, reinforcing cultural expectations of resilience (Davis, 2015). While this strength can be empowering, it also comes with costs. The SBW image may pressure women to compromise sleep, health, and personal wellness in pursuit of professional success, often while supporting others and masking vulnerability (Graham et al., 2020).

Navigating institutional culture in higher education intensifies these pressures. Nicole expressed the need to “over prepare, over perform, and over explain to be heard or be taken seriously,” a pattern she found mentally and emotionally draining. Her stress manifested physically through headaches, sleep disturbances, and bodily tension, and emotionally through persistent fatigue and a sense of overwhelm.

Tamika described a similar struggle. Though she did not view herself as an overachiever, others perceived her that way due to her willingness to “step up” when tasks outside of her duties needed to be done. This perception created friction, as colleagues misinterpreted her actions as ambitious and opportunist. Her stress produced physical symptoms such as elevated blood

pressure, headaches, and emotional eating. Eventually, she reached a breaking point and took medical leave under FMLA to prioritize her mental and physical health.

The literature confirms that chronic stress in academic leadership can result in serious health complications, ranging from migraines and muscle tension due to weakened immunity and reduced life expectancy (Cole & Secret, 2012; Golden, 2020; Slaymaker, 2020). Chronic fatigue and emotional depletion also hinder professional productivity and satisfaction linked to work-related stress. These symptoms can also cause deterioration in overall quality of life and diminish professional effectiveness (Springer et al., 2023).

Recognizing stress symptoms emerged as a critical first step in initiating effective coping mechanisms for these women. However, while strategies such as setting boundaries, taking medical leave, or practicing mindfulness provided short-term relief, the cumulative toll of institutional bias and overwork was not entirely mitigated. The findings support SBWC's assertion that strength, when demanded without reciprocal support or space for vulnerability, can exacerbate harm. These testimonies suggest that institutions must do more than encourage self-care, they must address the structural and cultural roots of stress to support Black women's long-term well-being in leadership.

Theme 3: Self-Care Activities

Recognizing stress was only the first step. Participants also described intentional self-care practices that allowed them to manage stress and preserve their leadership capacity and well-being. These practices can be described and explained in five broad categories: physical, spiritual, and emotional/mental self-care, boundary setting as a structural and personal strategy, and the role of institutional support. While these coping mechanisms helped mitigate immediate

stress, participants' ability to consistently engage in them was often shaped by the institutional culture and the level of support (or lack thereof) within their workplace environments.

Physical Self-Care

Many participants engaged in physical activity as a means to release stress and maintain health. Brianna described walking and going to the gym as small but meaningful acts that made her feel better. Dr. Harper similarly took walks, often integrating silent prayer during these times to help her process challenges and gain perspective. These physical practices were not only therapeutic, but also created intentional space for reflection and renewal.

Spiritual Self-Care

Spirituality emerged as a strong and consistent theme across participants' narratives. Several women shared that faith was foundational to their effective maneuvering through professional stress. Prayer, affirmations, and devotional readings helped them remain grounded amid the challenges of leadership. Nicole described starting her day with scripture and meditation, which centered her and reminded her she was not navigating these experiences alone. These practices align with the literature, which affirms that spiritual practices can serve as critical coping mechanisms for Black women facing intersectional pressures. (Adkins-Jackson et al., 2023)

Emotional and Mental Self-Care

Participants also emphasized emotional wellness and mental health support, including therapy and mindfulness practices. Nicole practiced deep breathing and meditation to manage her stress responses. Dr. Harper shared that she had attended counseling for both personal and professional concerns and encouraged other women to consider therapy. Several participants noted that while some institutions offered counseling services, commitment was limited by

availability, cultural mismatch, or stigma. However, the women overwhelmingly advocated for therapy, especially from culturally competent providers who understand the unique experiences of Black women in leadership. As McCall et al. (2025) noted, Black women are open to seeking therapy, but often prefer therapists who share their racial identity to ensure cultural resonance and deeper understanding.

Boundary Setting as Structural and Personal Strategy

Across all categories of self-care, boundary setting was among the most emphasized practices. Dr. Wells shared that she intentionally disconnects from work emails in the evening, takes lunch alone to recharge, and encourages her staff to use their leave benefits. She noted a stark contrast between herself and her White colleagues, who more freely decline extra work. Although she is still learning to say no, she is increasingly asking for additional support when needed. Similarly, Dr. Harper manages her workload by informing colleagues when she cannot take on new tasks and offering to reprioritize responsibilities as needed. These examples illustrate how boundary setting served as both a personal wellness strategy and an act of resistance against overextension. As Adkins-Jackson et al. (2023) suggest, reclaiming one's time is a powerful form of authority for Black women navigating systems that were not built with their wellness in mind.

The Role of Institutional Support

While participants described a range of self-care strategies, the ability to consistently engage in them was shaped by institutional culture. Environments that normalized overwork, failed to model boundaries, or lacked culturally competent mental health support limited the effectiveness of these practices. Some institutions offered counseling services, but access alone was not enough. Participants desired workplaces that actively supported wellness, respected

personal time, and fostered psychological safety. In this regard, while self-care helped alleviate stress, it could not fully counteract the structural demands and racialized expectations embedded in many academic environments.

Theme 4: Strategic Support Seeking

Mentorship

Mentorship and professional development emerged as critical tools for traversing the stressors of senior leadership. Participants consistently emphasized the need for trusted support systems. Individuals who not only understood the operational demands of higher education leadership but also the racialized and gendered dynamics Black women often encounter in these roles.

Informal Mentorship as Emotional and Cultural Support

Informal mentorship, often unstructured, peer-driven, or organically formed, served as an essential source of emotional relief and affirmation. Participants described the stress-relieving value of being able to talk with someone who "gets it." For Brianna, "having someone to vent to" was vital in high-stress moments. Carmen highlighted the importance of locating someone on campus who would "look out for you," offering an informal but protective relationship. Melanie was even more explicit in expressing the need to build trust with someone who is "Black like you, a Black woman." These informal networks provided a culturally grounded form of support often absent in institutional structures.

Informal mentorship also filled gaps where formal support mechanisms were lacking. Many participants created their own "sister circles" or leaned on relationships formed outside of their institution, suggesting that institutions often fail to recognize or provide the culturally competent mentorship Black women require to thrive.

Formal Mentorship and Institutional Facilitation

Formal mentorship, by contrast, refers to structured or institutionally supported relationships, sometimes tied to professional development programs or academic milestones. Dr. Wells, for instance, shared that her mentoring relationship with a college president developed during her dissertation process. She credited that relationship as a key factor in helping her transition successfully into senior leadership. Nicole similarly advised others to intentionally "surround yourself with mentors, sister friends, and thought partners who understand the unique weight you may carry in predominantly White or male-dominated spaces." Her use of both "mentors" and "sister friends" suggests the importance of blending formal and informal sources of support.

Yet formal mentorship opportunities were not always readily available or equitably distributed. Participants often had to seek out these connections independently, underscoring the institutional inconsistency in offering such support. Some women participated in professional development workshops or leadership institutes, which helped them build skills and expand their networks. However, not all institutions prioritized or invested in these opportunities. Even when professional development was offered, it did not always include mentorship tailored to the lived realities of Black women in executive roles.

Institutional Gaps and Inconsistent Support

While participants clearly valued both types of mentorships, their experiences revealed critical gaps in institutional support. Many institutions lacked structured mentorship programs specifically designed for women of color in leadership. This absence often pushed Black women to rely on external networks or facilitate the burden of mentorship for others without receiving it

themselves. These gaps reflect a broader institutional failure to recognize how systemic racism and sexism uniquely shape the leadership experiences of Black women.

Research by Gause (2022) echoes this finding, noting that Black women leaders often delay advancement without targeted mentorship and professional support. Institutions that do not intentionally build inclusive support systems may inadvertently contribute to burnout and leadership attrition among Black women. Moreover, when professional development opportunities are inconsistently offered or lack cultural relevance, they risk reinforcing, rather than reducing, the very stressors they aim to address.

Strategic Support Seeking as a Coping and Advancement Strategy

Ultimately, mentorship and professional development served dual purposes for participants: they were both coping strategies and tools for advancement. These relationships and resources provided spaces for belonging, validation, and reflection, all of which are crucial for buffering the chronic stress associated with navigating executive roles as a Black woman. However, the burden of seeking and sustaining these support systems often were the responsibility of the individual, rather than being meaningfully embedded into institutional culture.

To truly support the well-being and advancement of Black women in senior leadership, institutions must move beyond surface-level inclusion and invest in culturally responsive mentorship programs, leadership pipelines, and professional development opportunities that affirm both competence and identity.

Implications for Policy and Practice

This study not only contributes to the literature on how Black women in senior leadership at two-year colleges manage stress, but also offers actionable insights for institutional,

professional, and personal-level changes. The findings point to systemic gaps and cultural norms that exacerbate stress, and highlight the need for strategic, equity-focused reforms.

Addressing the Double Bind of Racism and Sexism

Participants described persistent encounters with the intersecting burdens of race and gender. Dr. Harper recalled having to defend herself against baseless claims made by a White female employee. Claims that, despite a lack of evidence, were taken seriously by institutional leadership and ultimately hindered her career progression. Similarly, Dr. Wells spoke of being forced to defend her Black staff in ways her White staff did not need defending, and Carmen recounted repeated experiences of gender bias from faculty and senior leaders.

Recommendations:

- Institutions must implement mandatory, annual DEI training focused on the intersection of race and gender in leadership.
- Leadership development programs specifically for Black women, facilitated by racially and gender-aligned mentors, should be established.
- Conduct annual equity audits to ensure Black women leaders are not disproportionately overburdened or undercompensated.

Institutional Wellness Policies: Prioritizing Mental and Physical Health

Many participants reported seeking therapy, often due to the emotional toll of their roles. However, culturally competent care was not always accessible or effective. This idea echoes McCall et al. (2025), who found that Black women frequently discontinue therapy when providers lack cultural awareness or empathy.

Participants also internalized guilt over using paid leave benefits, stemming from the need to appear perpetually strong, a sentiment rooted in the SBWC theory. This internalized expectation results in reluctance to rest, even when well-being is compromised.

Recommendations:

- Employ culturally competent mental health professionals as part of employee wellness offerings.
- Institutionalize mental health days into leadership contracts, reinforcing well-being as a professional right, not a privilege.
- Normalize rest and psychological recovery to challenge the false narrative that strong leaders must sacrifice their health.

Supporting Self-Care as a Professional Expectation

Participants engaged in informal self-care practices such as prayer, walking, and setting boundaries. However, these efforts often occurred outside formal institutional structures. As Adkins-Jackson et al. (2023) suggest, intersectional stress requires more than personal coping, it demands structural support.

Recommendations:

- Integrate personal wellness goals into annual performance planning.
- Encourage remote or flexible scheduling, which participants identified as beneficial for focus and stress reduction.
- Formally recognize self-care as a leadership competency rather than an extracurricular activity.

Facilitating Strategic Support Seeking

Despite their qualifications, Black women remain underrepresented in senior leadership. Participants described the value of mentorship and professional development in coping with leadership stress. Still, much of the support they received was informally sought out, highlighting institutional failure to provide consistent, structured support systems.

Recommendations:

- Develop formal mentorship programs that match Black women with mentors who understand their racial and gendered experiences.
- Fund regional or national retreats that serve as spaces for Black women to build community, develop leadership skills, and affirm their experiences.
- Shift the burden of finding support away from individuals by institutionalizing mentorship and peer support with leadership pipelines.

Operationalizing Transformational Leadership through an Equity Lens

This study's findings emphasize that managing stress for Black women in leadership is inseparable from their racial and gender identities. Participants consistently led with empathy, purpose, and resilience, even in unsupportive environments. Their leadership style closely reflects the principles of transformational leadership, individualized consideration, inspirational motivation, intellectual stimulation, and idealized influence.

Recommendations:

- Embed equity-conscious transformational leadership training into professional development programs for current and aspiring leaders.
- Align leadership evaluations with values such as empathy, collaboration, and inclusion, qualities that many Black women leaders already embody.

- Integrate case-based learning that features real experiences of Black women in leadership, like those in this study, to humanize systemic challenges and foster empathy in institutional decision-making.

By anchoring leadership development in both transformational values and an equity lens, institutions can better support Black women and fundamentally reshape leadership culture. This shift has the potential to improve retention, well-being, and institutional effectiveness, creating environments where all leaders can thrive.

Conclusion

The implications outlined above respond directly to the central purpose of this study, to explore how Black women in senior leadership at two-year colleges manage stress, and to identify the institutional, cultural, and personal conditions that shape their experiences. The findings reveal that stress management for these leaders cannot be separated from the intersecting dynamics of race and gender, or from the cultural expectations embedded in the SBWC framework. Participants relied on internal strength and informal strategies to persist in environments that often failed to acknowledge or address their unique burdens. Yet, their leadership styles, rooted in empathy, vision, and resilience, demonstrate the transformational potential they bring to higher education. Institutions must move beyond performative diversity statements and implement equity-driven leadership policies that affirm the well-being, advancement, and leadership legitimacy of Black women. As a result, these institutions not only support the individual leader, but also signal a broader cultural shift toward inclusion, sustainability, and systemic change in higher education.

Future Research

This research explored how Black women in senior leadership positions in two-year institutions manage stress. While the study offered valuable insight, it was limited to a small sample of participants across three regions of the United States. Given this limitation and the value of the findings, several avenues of future research can expand and deepen our understanding of how Black women in higher education leadership navigate stress.

First, future studies could broaden the institutional context by including Black women leaders at four-year colleges and universities. These institutions differ in size, governance, visibility, and culture, which may influence the types and intensity of stressors experienced. Expanding the scope to include both public and private four-year institutions would allow for comparative analyses that reveal how organizational complexity, resource access, and leadership expectations shape stress dynamics and coping strategies.

Second, since strategic support-seeking emerged as a central theme in this study, longitudinal research is warranted to examine how sustained mentorship relationships affect Black women's leadership trajectories and well-being over time. Tracking participants across multiple years could provide deeper insight into how mentorship influences resilience, role satisfaction, and retention. Mixed-method designs, combining interviews, reflective journals, and wellness assessments, could further enrich the data and strengthen causal interpretations of mentorship's impact.

Third, the current findings highlighted a range of physical and psychological symptoms of stress among participants. Future research could focus on the health consequence of chronic stress for Black women in leadership, using a more health-centered lens. Partnering with medical or public health researchers may allow for physiological measures, blood pressure, sleep

patterns, and cortisol levels, to be analyzed alongside qualitative narratives, offering a holistic understanding of how racialized stress manifests in the body and mind.

Fourth, given that many recommendations from this study emphasized institutional responsibility, future research could investigate the policies, programs, and resources currently offered by human resources and organizational development departments in higher education. Interviewing HR professionals and comparing institutional documents could help identify misalignments between policy and practice, particularly concerning support for minoritized leaders. This research could ascertain whether Black women leaders find those resources accessible or relevant.

A combination of these future research directions can support a more equitable higher education landscape by centering Black women's leadership experiences and identifying sustainable strategies to reduce stress, strengthen support systems, and transform institutional culture.

Conclusion

Black women in senior leadership roles at two-year institutions continue to endure the complex realities of racism, sexism, and chronic stress with resilience and intention. Through this study, their voices revealed not only the institutional challenges they experience, but also the strength, strategies, and support systems they rely on to survive and lead. These narratives underscore the urgent need for systemic change, where wellness is embedded in leadership culture, and equity is not just aspirational but actionable. Grounded in Black Feminist Thought and the Strong Black Woman Collective, this research illuminates the toll of invisibility and the power of visibility. It calls upon institutions to recognize that supporting Black women leaders is not a matter of cultural competency alone, but of structural justice. As the academy moves

toward a more inclusive future, this study offers a roadmap centering well-being, reclaiming self-care as strategy, and reimaging leadership through an equity-driven lens.

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Appendix A

Research Flyer

Managing Stress: Black Women Senior Leaders in Higher Education

Seeking Research Participants

If you are a Black woman in a senior leadership position at a 2-year institution in Student Affairs, you may be eligible to participate in a research study designed to understand how Black women in senior leadership roles manage stress and ascend to key leadership roles. This study aims to help other Black women reach their career goals by managing stress in higher education. There is a gap in the research as it relates to Black women managing stress in leadership roles and this research will close the gap and inspire more Black women to obtain and keep these senior leadership roles. Eligibility

- Black Woman in a Senior Level Student Affairs Role (Vice President, Dean, Associate Dean, Director)
- Worked in this role within the past 3 years
- Work in a 2-Year Institution
- Experienced stress while in this role
- Willing to participate in a research study

Complete the online survey below to see if you qualify.
https://docs.google.com/forms/d/e/1FAIpQLSepggIhdDRZaOpTju3S-lbmtvd0Gh4Scc1DQXwbm43nzRqwtg/viewform?usp=dialog

Interviews Conducted via Microsoft Teams

For more information contact:

Collice King
Doctoral Candidate
Governors State University

cking@govst.edu

Appendix B

Survey

https://docs.google.com/forms/d/e/1FAIpQLSepggIhdDRZaOpTju3S-lbmtvd0Gh4Scc1DQXwbm43nzRqwtg/viewform?usp=dialog

What is your Race?

- Black
- African American
- African
- Afro Caribbean
- Other - _____

What is your Gender?

- Female
- Male

Do you work in a 2-year higher education institution?

- Yes
- No

Do you work in a Student Affairs position in a 2-year higher education institution?

- Yes
- No

Do you currently or in the past three years held a role in a 2-year institution as a Vice President, Dean, Associate Dean, or Director in Student Affairs?

- Yes
- No

Please list your job title in which you worked in Student Affairs.

_____

Have you experienced stress in your leadership role in Student Affairs?

- Yes
- No
- Maybe

Are you willing to participate in an interview regarding Managing Stress: Black Women in Senior Leadership Positions in Higher Education Institutions?

- Yes
- No
- Maybe

Please list the name of the institution in which you worked in Student Affairs.

_____

Please add your name and contact information if you are willing to be a participant in this research.

_____

Appendix C

Interview Questions

1. Can you describe a time when you felt significant stress in your leadership role? How did you recognize and respond to that stress?
2. What are the primary sources of stress you experienced as a Black woman in a senior-level Student Affairs position at a 2-year institution?
3. What strategies or coping mechanisms have you developed to manage work-related stress, and how effective do you find them?
4. How do your experiences with stress management differ from those of your colleagues in similar leadership roles who do not share your identity as a Black woman?
5. What institutional support or resources (if any) have been beneficial in helping you manage stress, and what additional support do you believe is needed?
6. How does your leadership style influence your ability to manage stress and maintain well-being in your role?
7. What advice would you give to other Black women aspiring to senior leadership roles in Student Affairs regarding managing stress and maintaining resilience?

Appendix D

Statement of Informed Consent

Title of Research Study: Managing Stress: Black Women in Senior Leadership Positions in Higher Education

Principal Investigator: Collice King, Dr. Quincy Martin

Key Information:

The following is a short summary of this study to help you decide whether to participate or not. More detailed information is listed later on in this consent form.

- I am inviting you to participate in a research study regarding managing stress. Stress is an overarching problem for Black women in Higher Education institutions. This research aims to understand how Black women in senior leadership positions in student affairs at 2-year higher education institutions mange stress. We want to learn the different types of stress experienced while in senior leadership positions and ways in which these women have managed the stress to ascend or stay in their leadership roles.
- Participation in this study is voluntary, and you can choose not to participate or withdraw at any time without penalty.
- I am asking you to be part of this study which will require a virtual interview, on Zoom, that will consist of 7 questions and a few probing questions addressing managing stress, the type of stress experienced, discrimination, compensation, and physical and/or mental health issues related to stress. All answers will be treated as confidential; your name and other personal identifiable information will not be associated with the data or any publications that might result from this study. The interview section of this study will be audio recorded to eliminate the possibility of errors when reporting the information. The recordings will be transcribed for analysis and evaluation purposes. Once completed, the records will be destroyed after all data has been published.
- I expect that your participation in this study will require one, 60-90 minutes virtual interview.
- The risks of participating are minimal to no known risks. However, feelings of discomfort may occur during interviews.
- The benefits of the study include your participation is likely to help other Black women manage their stress and obtain higher roles in higher education.
- As a token of appreciation, we are offering participants thank you emails.

Why am I being asked to participate in this research study?

You are being invited to take part in this research because we feel that your experience as a senior level leader in a student affairs role can contribute much to our understanding and knowledge of how Black women in these positions manage stress.

What should I know about participating in a research study?

- Whether or not you participate is up to you. You can choose not to participate.

- You can agree to participate and then later change your mind.
- Your decision will not be held against you or result in penalty.
- You can ask all the questions that you want before you decide.

What happens if I agree to participate in the research study?
If you agree to participate in the study, you will be asked to sign a consent and then complete demographic questions, prior to the study. The study will take place virtually and a Microsoft Teams link with a meeting ID and password will be sent to the email that the participant provided. If you sign the consent, you are also agreeing to let the research audio record the data provided. A separate consent to be recorded will not be required.
What happens if I do not want to be in this research?

Participation in research is voluntary. You can decide to participate or not to participate.

What happens if I say "Yes", but I change my mind later?

You can leave the research study at any time, and it will not be held against you. If you decide to leave the study, your information will not be used.

What happens to the information collected for the research?

Your name and other personal identifiable information will not be associated with the data. All information obtained in this study will be kept extremely confidential. All materials received from this study will be securely stored in a location with restricted access to administrators and professional staff directly related to this study.

Data Sharing

De-identified data from the study could be used for future research studies or shared with other investigators without your additional informed consent.

Who can I talk to?

If you have questions, concerns, or complaints, you may contact Collice King at cking@student.govst.edu or at 708-534-7272. You may also contact Dr. Quincy Martin III, doctoral capstone chair, at qmartin@govst.edu or by phone at 708-235-7567.

This research has been reviewed and approved by an Institutional Review Board ("IRB"). You may contact the IRB at irb@govst.edu if you have questions or concerns regarding your rights as a research participant. You may also contact the Director of Sponsored Programs and Research at 708-235-2846.

Signature for Adult 18 or older

Signing here means that you are agreeing (consenting) to participate in this research and that you are giving the researchers permission to use the information that they collect from your participation.

_____ _____

Signature of participant Date

_____

Printed name of participant

_____ _____

Signature of person obtaining consent Date

_____

Printed name of person obtaining consent

Appendix E

Participant Email

Subject: Invitation to Participate in Research Study on "Managing Stress: Black Women in Senior Leadership Positions in Higher Education"

Dear [*Recipient's Name*],

I hope this email finds you well. My name is Collice King and I am a Doctoral Candidate in the Interdisciplinary Leadership program at Governors State University. I am reaching out to invite you to participate in an exciting research study I am conducting on Managing Stress: Black Women in Senior Leadership Positions in Higher Education.

The study aims to understand how Black women senior leaders in higher education manage stress. Your unique insights and experiences would be incredibly valuable to our research, and we believe that your participation could make a significant impact.

Participation in this study involves attending an interview virtually via Microsoft Teams. I estimate that it will take approximately 60-90 minutes of your time. All information collected will be kept confidential and used solely for research purposes.

If you are interested in participating or have any questions, please reply to this email or contact me directly at cking@govst.edu. I would be delighted to have you on board and contribute to this important research.

Thank you for considering this invitation. I look forward to the possibility of working with you.

Best regards,

Collice King

Doctoral Candidate

Governors State University

This message is being sent to publicly available email addresses for the purpose of participant recruitment.